HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

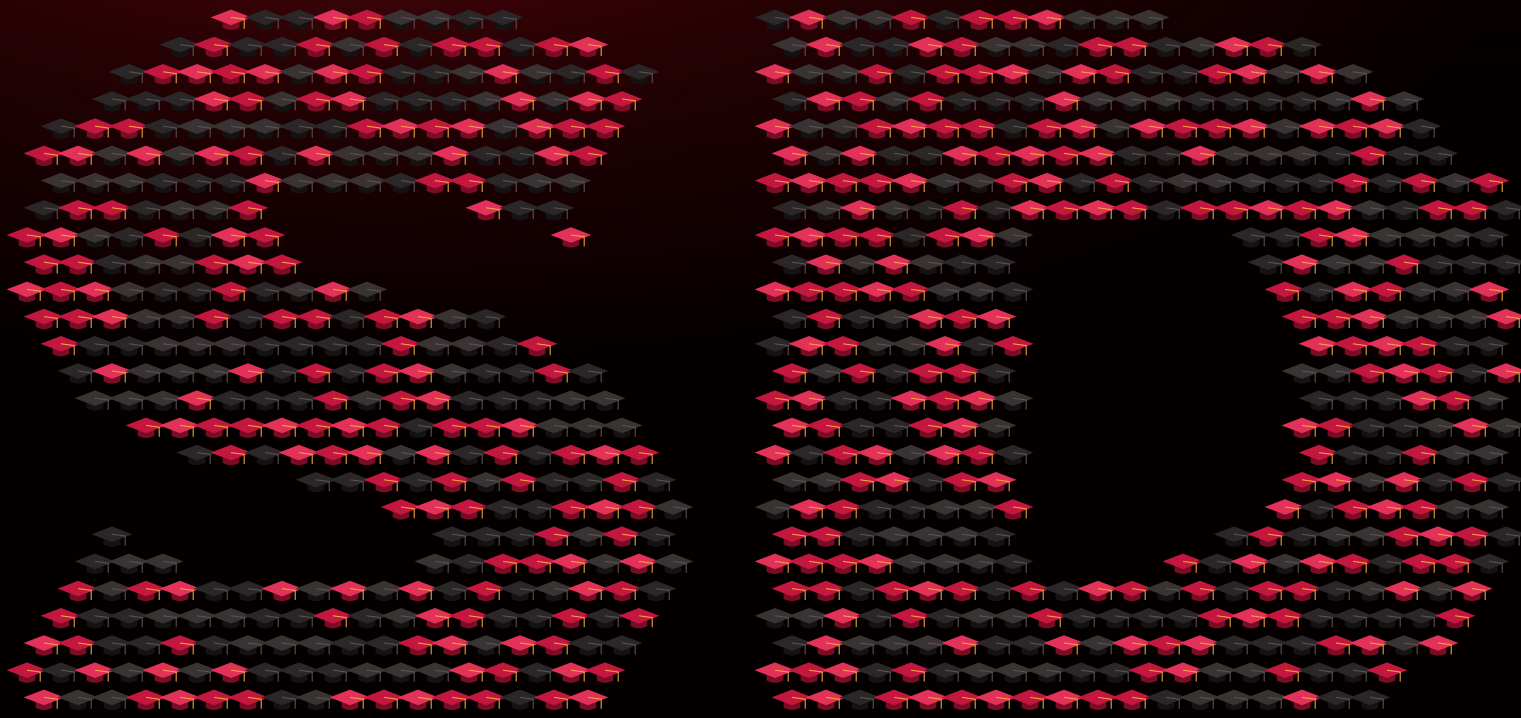
NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 South Dakota Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston

Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **48 in every 100**, mark the international share of South Dakota's STEM master's degrees.



The 2026 South Dakota Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 93

Authors

Emerson Victoria Johnston is a research assistant with the Hoover Institution's Technology Policy Accelerator. A Knight-Hennessy Scholar, she holds a master's in international policy from Stanford University, and is on leave from its master's program in the history of science, technology, environment, and medicine.

Dr. Amy Zegart is the Morris Arnold and Nona Jean Cox Senior Fellow at the Hoover Institution, director of Hoover's Technology Policy Accelerator, and a senior fellow and associate director at Stanford University's Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence.

Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to South Dakota: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence
The 2026 South Dakota Talent Profile

How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 South Dakota Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from federal sources: the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, as the backbone, together with NAEP, NSF's surveys of graduate students, doctorates and research funding, USAspending.gov, DHS and ICE SEVIS data, the Department of Labor, USCIS, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, and USPTO PatentsView. Each figure names its source, and the Sources page lists all of them. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 South Dakota Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What South Dakota's numbers say

1. **International students earn 48% of South Dakota's STEM master's degrees,** 4.3 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 22nd of 51 on dependence. The share is 40% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 4.8% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **South Dakota awarded 277 STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 0.2% of the U.S. total and 39th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed 2.3×, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 70% of master's degrees (272 degrees; U.S. 65%). One STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates is majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** South Dakota ranks 2nd of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: South Dakota 48%, North Dakota 36%, Delaware 72%, Montana 18%, Hawaii 16%.
5. **58% of South Dakota's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 5.4% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (3.39K) than residents left (1.83K), a net gain of 1.56K; the top destination for those leaving was Minnesota.

48%

of the STEM master's degrees South Dakota awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SOUTH DAKOTA · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

54.2K #46
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +0.9% since 2015

277 #39
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · 2.31× since 2015

48% #22
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +10.4 pp since 2015

13% #26
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +2.0 pp since 2015

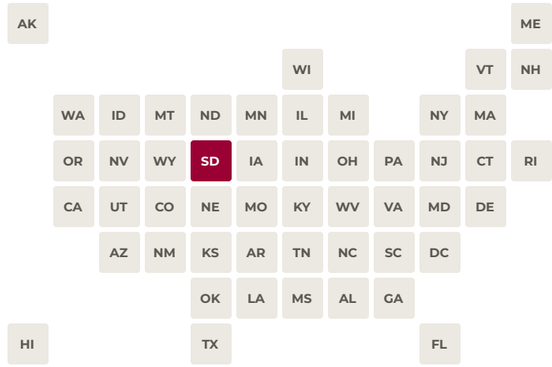
26% #15
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +6.7 pp since 2015

58% #40
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +7.8 pp since 2015

$9.61K #35
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +28% since 2015

58% #45
First-time students from in state, 2024
−4.0 pp since 2016

$79.3K #47
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −7.6% since 2016



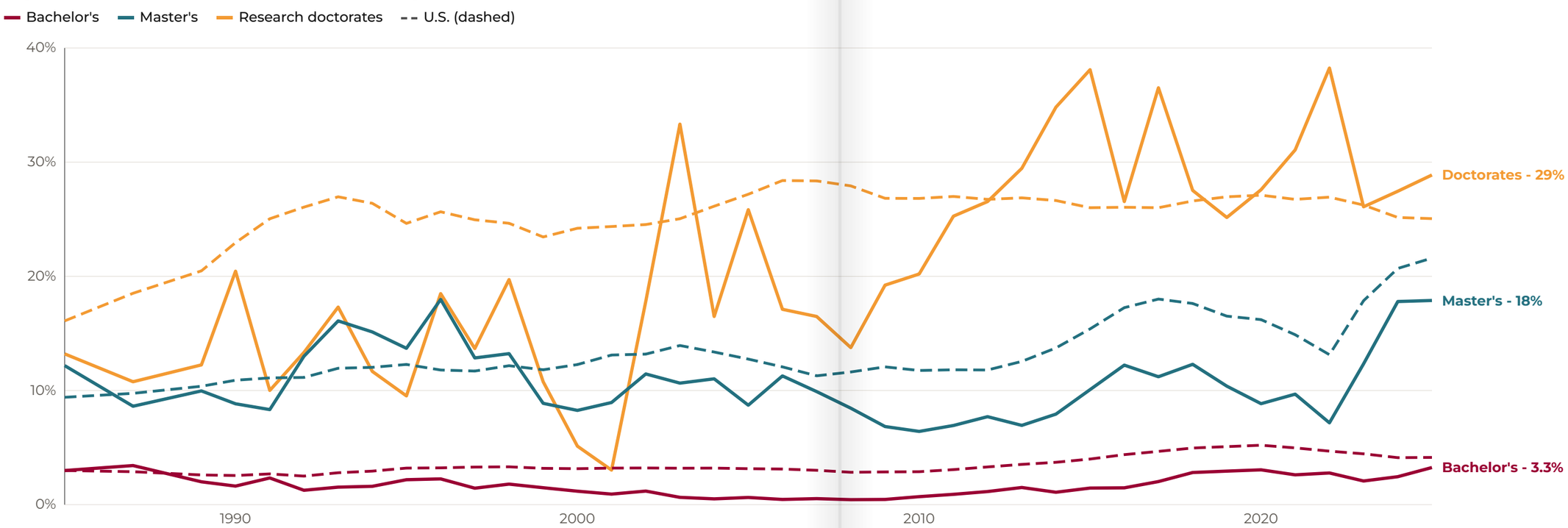
Badges give South Dakota's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

South Dakota ranks 22nd of 51 on the international share of STEM master's, at 48% in 2025 against 52% for the U.S.

Figure 1 What Share of South Dakota's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 13% of South Dakota's graduate enrollment and 3.4% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 3.3% of bachelor's, 18% of master's and 29% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 4.8% of STEM bachelor's, 48% of STEM master's and 40% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 0.2% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 39th of 51.

13%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **26th** of 51 · +2.0 pp since 2015

18%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

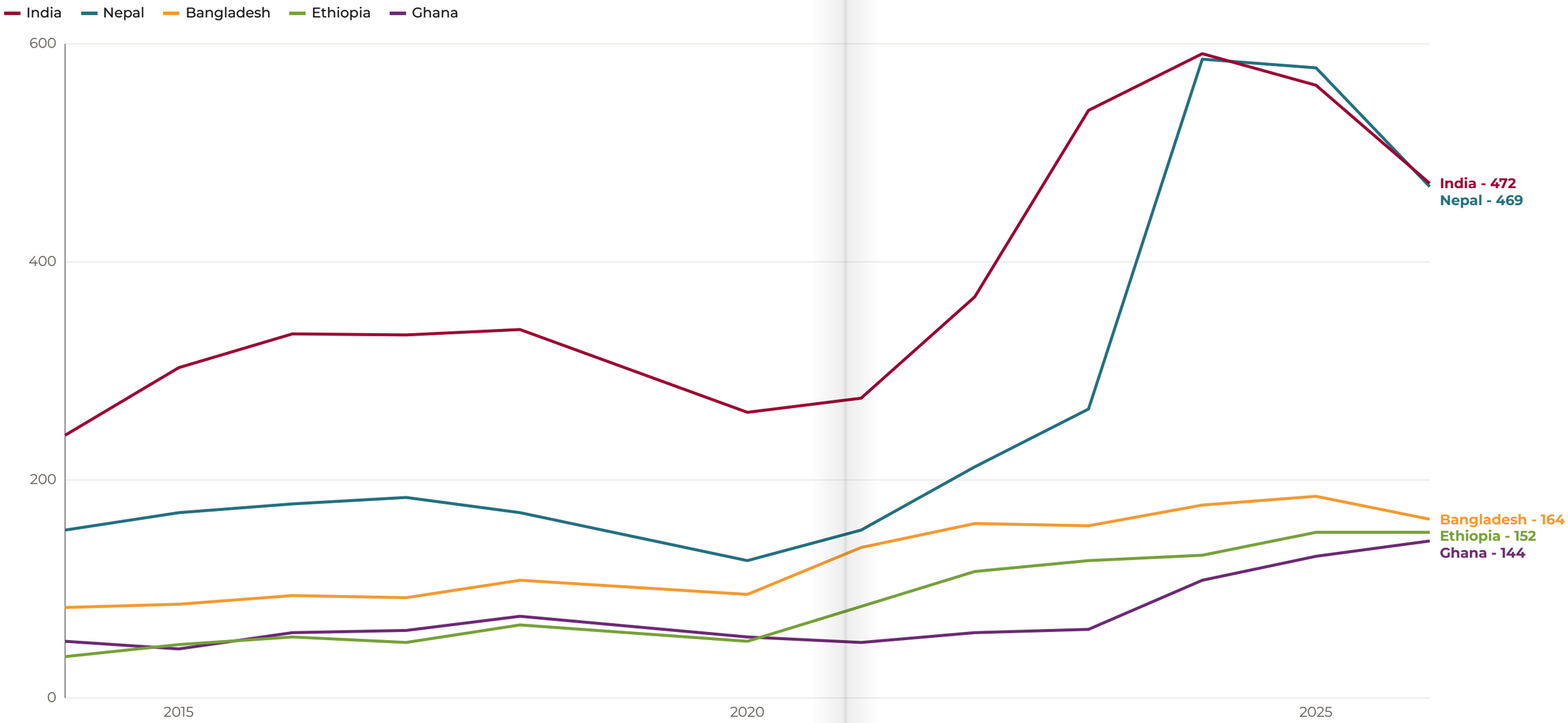
U.S. **22%** · **23rd** of 51 · +7.8 pp since 2015

48%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **22nd** of 51 · +10.4 pp since 2015

Figure 2 Where Do South Dakota's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, South Dakota had 2.77K active international students in SEVIS, 43rd of 51. India accounted for 17% of them and Nepal for 17%, against 27% and 2.9% nationally.

Students came from 121 countries, but the two largest supplied 34%. The state's total is up 46% since 2015, when it stood at 1.91K.

2.77K
Active international students, October 2026
43rd of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

17%
From India
U.S. **27%**

63%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

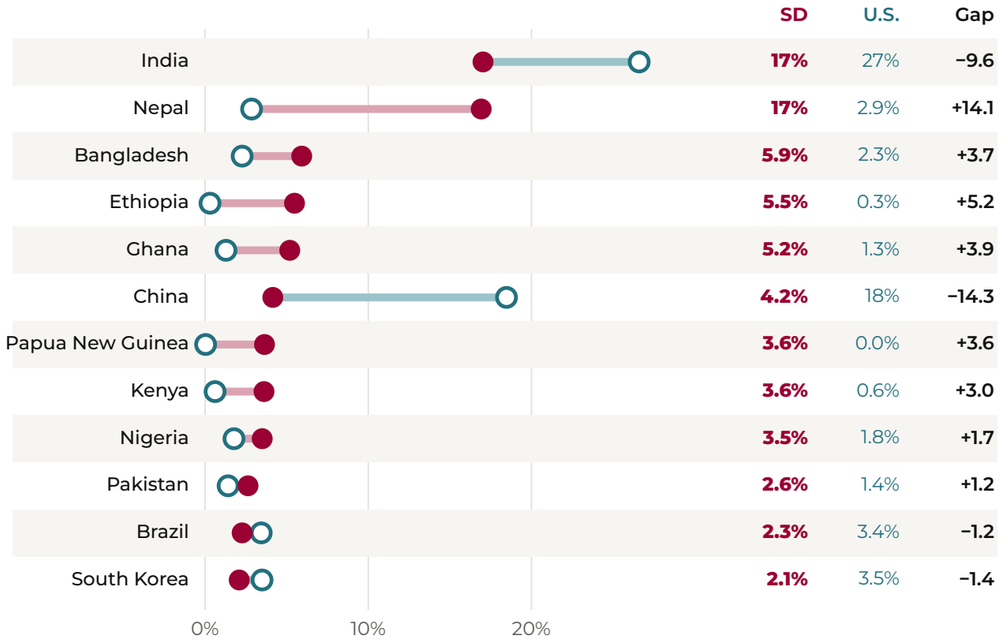
How Does South Dakota's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, South Dakota had **2.77K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 43rd among the 50 states and DC and **0.2%** of the U.S. total. They came from 121 countries.

India supplied **17%** of them, against 27% nationally, and Nepal **17%**, against 2.9%. Bangladesh (5.9%), Ethiopia (5.5%), and Ghana (5.2%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **34%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 33rd among the states, against 28% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is South Dakota's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

2.77K
Active international students, October 2026
43rd of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

17%
From India
U.S. **27%**

17%
From Nepal
U.S. **2.9%**

121
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 4.2% from 2025 and up 46% since 2015, when it stood at 1.91K. Its share of all U.S. international students is up 0.1 points since 2015, to **0.2%**.

Since 2015, the number of students from India went from 303 to 472, Nepal's from 170 to 469, and Bangladesh's from 86 to 164.

Over the same years, the number from Ethiopia went from 49 to 152 and Ghana's from 45 to 144. The table gives each country's count for the first, previous and latest years.

Table 1 International Students in South Dakota, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	1.91K	2.89K	**2.77K**	+46%	1.19M	43rd
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.2%	0.2%	**0.2%**	+0.1 pp	–	43rd
Countries of citizenship represented	116	124	**121**	+4.3%	219	44th
Share from the two largest countries of origin	28%	39%	**34%**	+5.6 pp	45%	33rd
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	303	562	**472**	+56%	27%	17%
Nepal	170	578	**469**	+176%	2.9%	17%
Bangladesh	86	185	**164**	+91%	2.3%	5.9%
Ethiopia	49	152	**152**	–	0.3%	5.5%
Ghana	45	130	**144**	–	1.3%	5.2%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply South Dakota's International STEM Students?

1.74K of South Dakota's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **63%** of the total against 63% nationally, up 55% since 2015.

Bachelor's students were the largest group, **680**. Nepal supplied 18% of them and Papua New Guinea 13%.

STEM doctoral students went from 289 in 2015 to **434**, and STEM master's students from 433 to 621.

1.74K

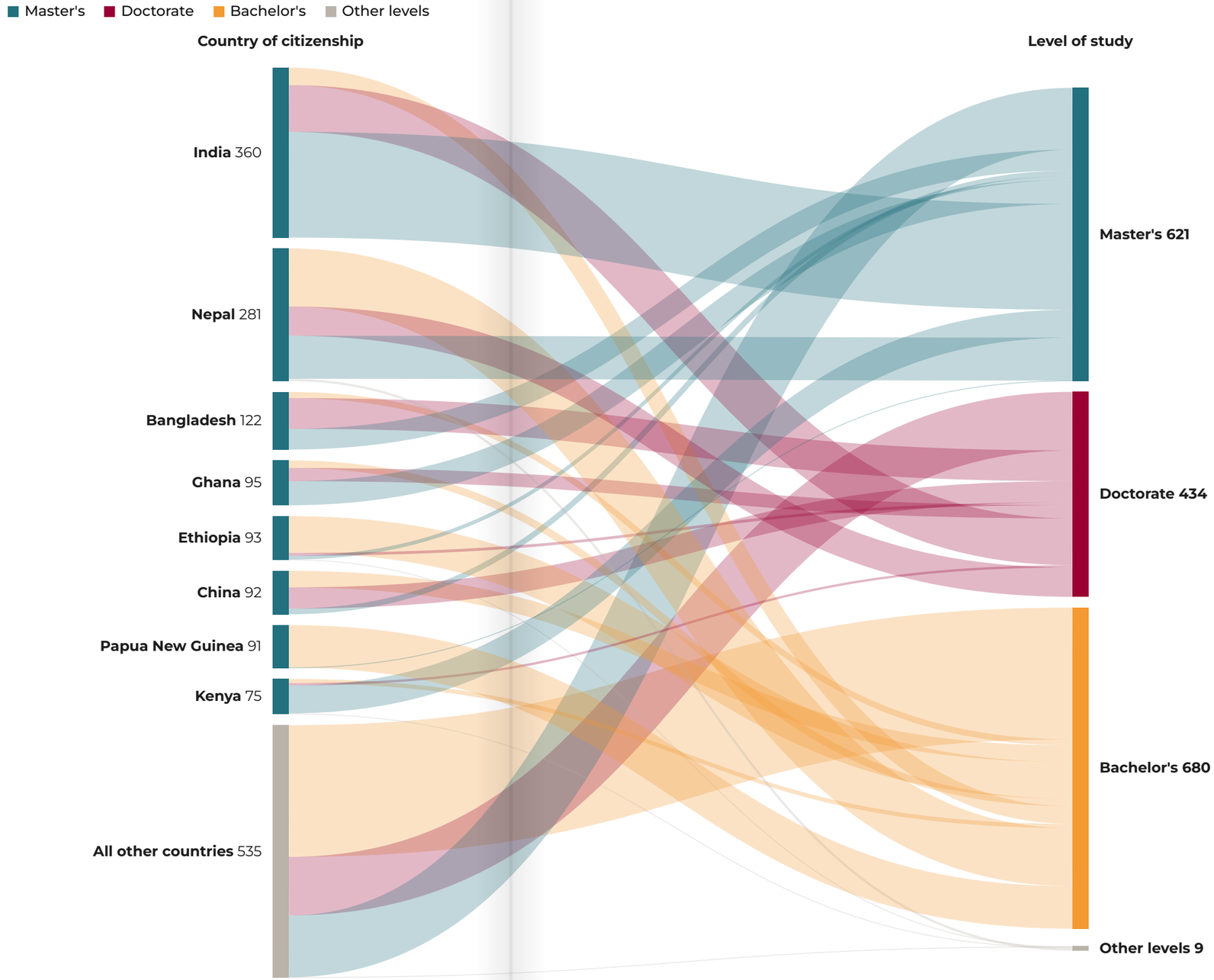
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **43rd** of 51 · +55% since 2015

63%

Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

621

Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **42nd** of 51 · +43% since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

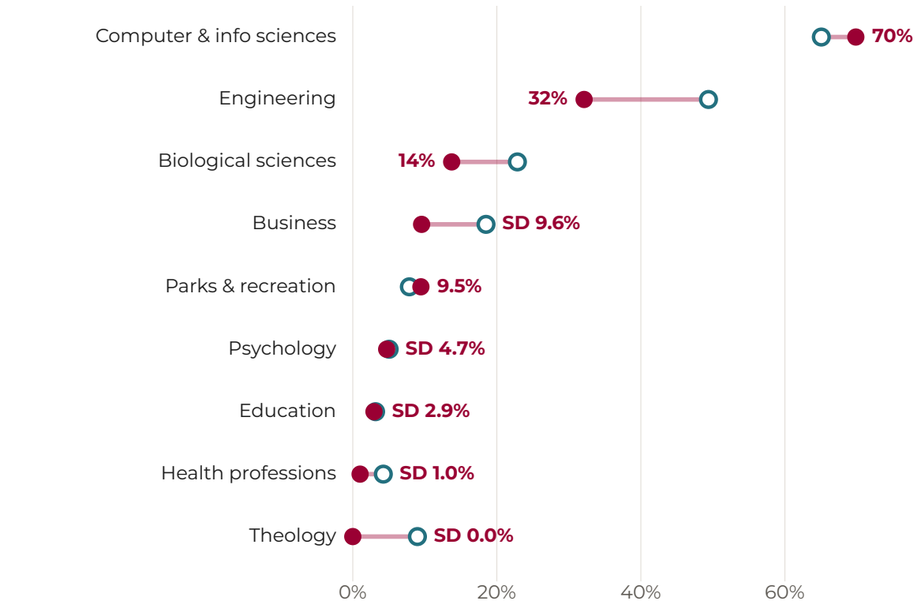
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How International Are South Dakota's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in South Dakota in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. International students earned the largest shares of master's degrees in computer & info sciences (70%, against 65% for the U.S.), engineering (32%, against 49% for the U.S.), and biological sciences (14%, against 23% for the U.S.).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

18%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **23rd** of 51

48%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **22nd** of 51

70%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **19th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: South Dakota first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. International students earned 70% of the master's degrees in computer & info sciences, against 65% for the U.S.

Fields with an international majority. International students earned more than half of the master's degrees in one STEM field.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	8.5% / 8.6%	**70% / 65%**	2.7% / 56%
Engineering	3.5% / 7.2%	**32% / 49%**	72% / 55%
Engineering technology	1.8% / 4.5%	**50% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	1.6% / 17%	**30% / 55%**	– / 53%
Physical sciences	2.9% / 6.0%	**24% / 33%**	– / 38%
Biological sciences	5.0% / 3.4%	**14% / 23%**	– / 23%
Natural resources	0.0% / 2.0%	**– / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	5.4% / 7.3%	**– / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in South Dakota / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

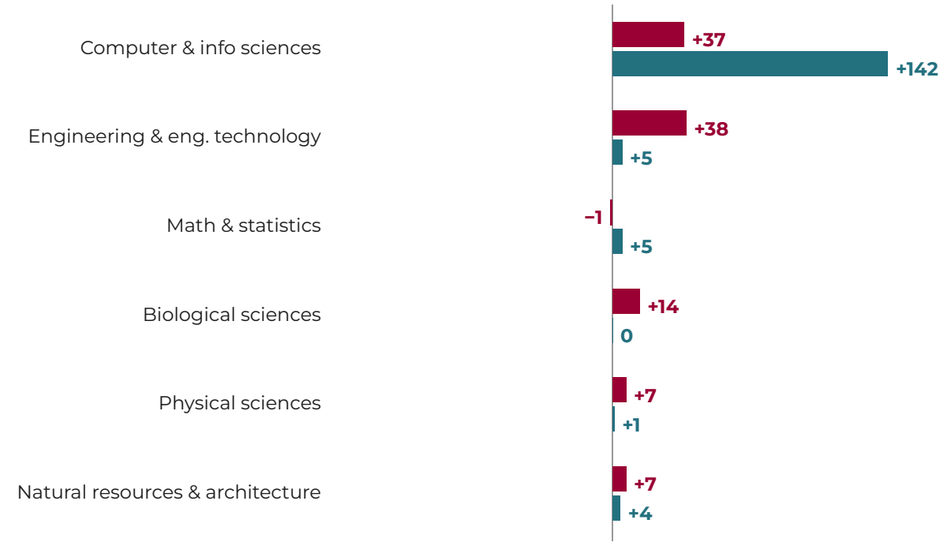
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has South Dakota's STEM Master's Output Grown?

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in South Dakota between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. The state awarded 580 in 2025 and 321 in 2015, a change of +157 for international students and +102 for domestic students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

277
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **39th** of 51

27%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **10th** of 51

0.2%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
39th of 51

6.6
STEM master's per STEM research doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **17th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in South Dakota in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. The share was 27% in 2025, against 23% for the U.S., 10th among the states, down 0.5 points from 27% in 2024 and up 6.0 points since 2015, when it was 21%.

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	93	**272**	+192%	190	52%	70%
Engineering & eng. technology	126	**169**	+34%	60	44%	36%
Math & statistics	23	**27**	–	8	–	–
Biological sciences	37	**51**	–	7	19%	14%
Physical sciences	25	**33**	–	8	–	24%
Natural resources & architecture	17	**28**	–	4	–	–

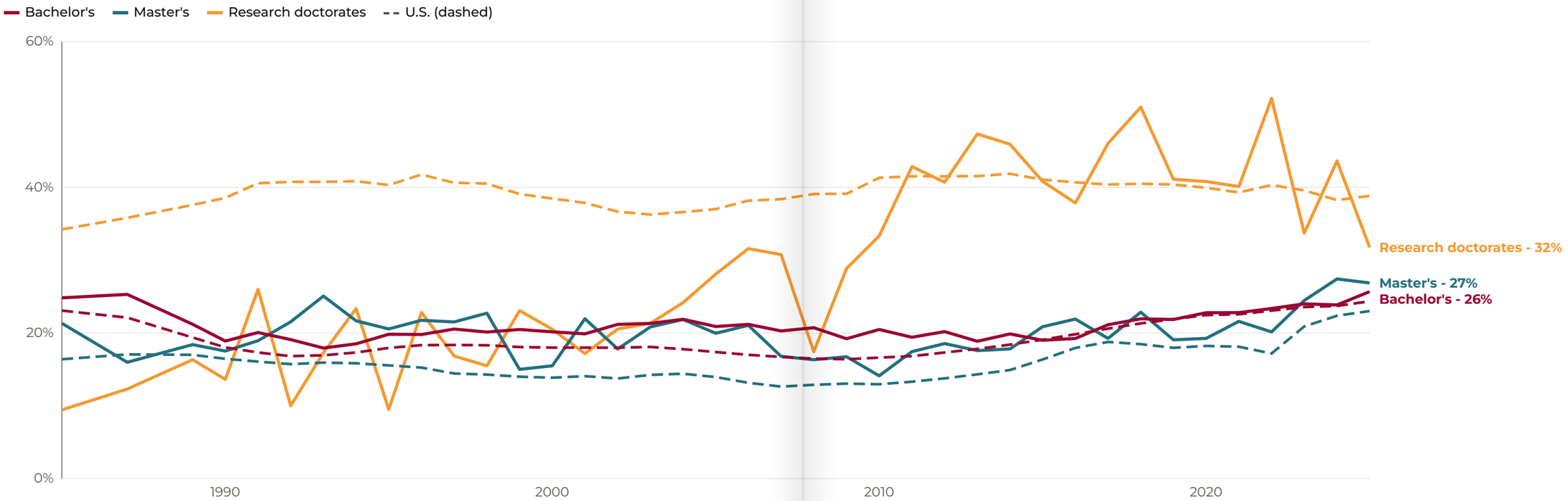
STEM master's degrees awarded in South Dakota, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

South Dakota ranks 10th of 51 on the STEM share of master's, at 27% in 2025 against 23% for the U.S.

Figure 7 How Much of South Dakota's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 26% of South Dakota's bachelor's degrees, 27% of its master's and 32% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 6.0 points since 2015, and the state ranks 10th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 15th of 51.

26%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **15th** of 51 · +6.7 pp since 2015

27%

STEM share of master's, 2025

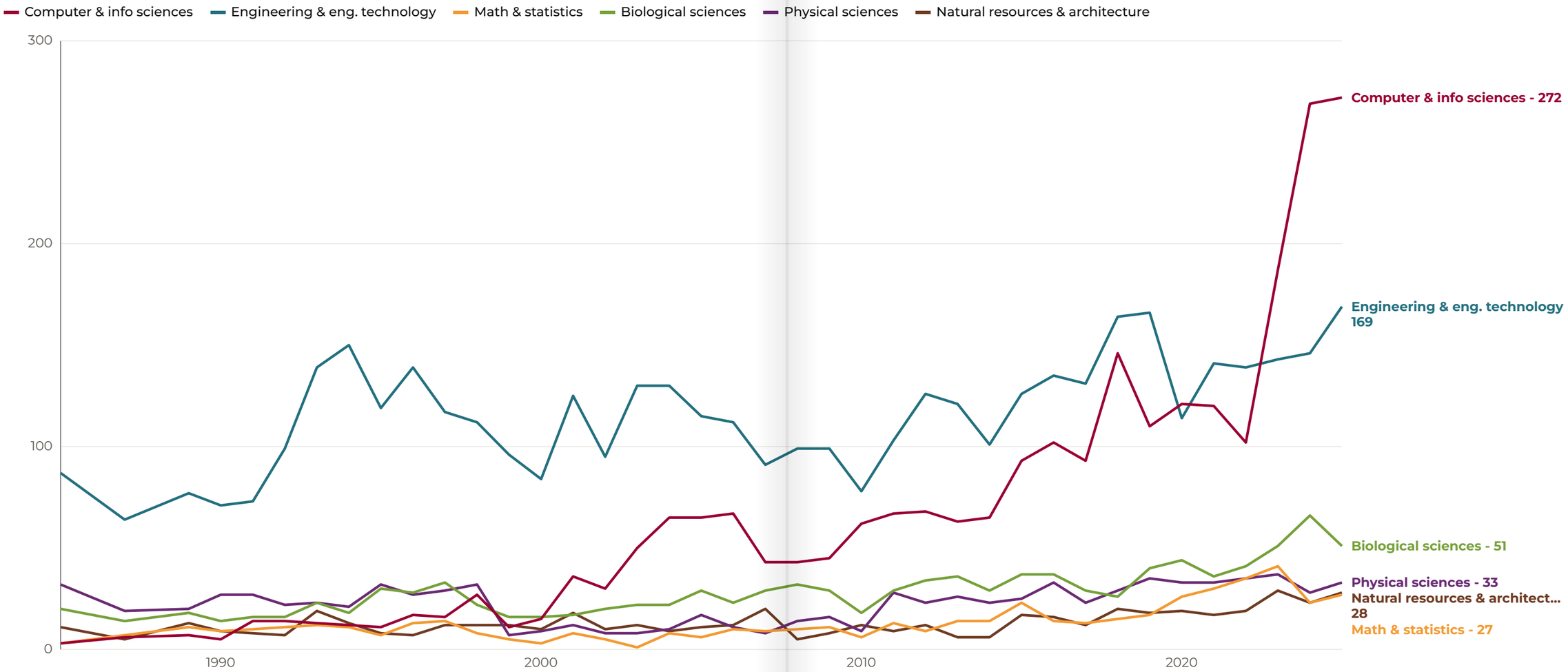
U.S. **23%** · **10th** of 51 · +6.0 pp since 2015

32%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **41st** of 51 · −9.0 pp since 2015

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce South Dakota's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Computer & info sciences produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 272, followed by engineering & eng. technology (169) and biological sciences (51). Master's degrees in computer & info sciences are up 192% since 2015.

International students earned 277 of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 0.2% of the national total (39th of 51).

277

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **39th** of 51 · 2.31× since 2015

0.2%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

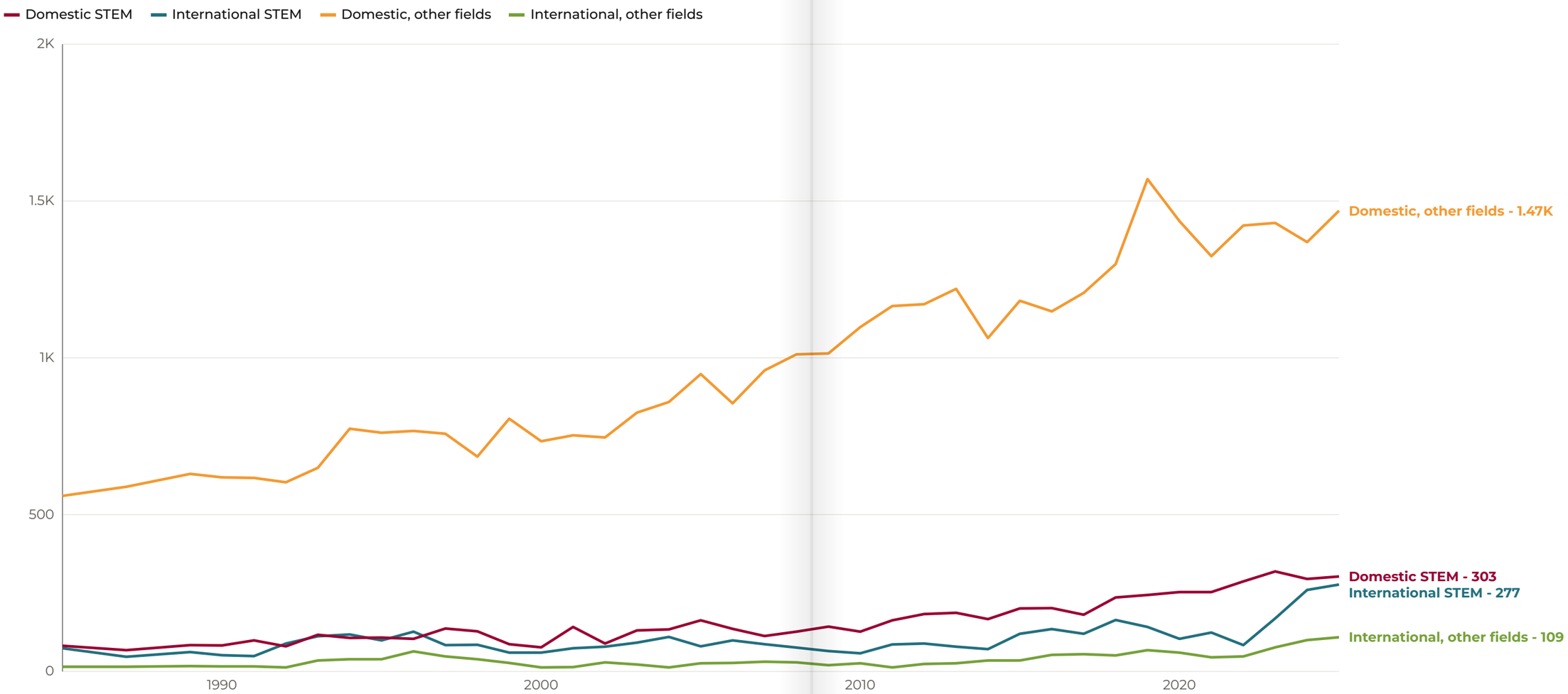
39th of 51 · 0.0 pp since 2015

70%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **19th** of 47 · +18.2 pp since 2015

Figure 9 Who Earns South Dakota's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 157 more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 102 more to domestic students.

International students earn 48% of South Dakota's STEM master's but 6.9% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

18%

Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **23rd** of 51 · +7.8 pp since 2015

48%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **22nd** of 51 · +10.4 pp since 2015

6.6

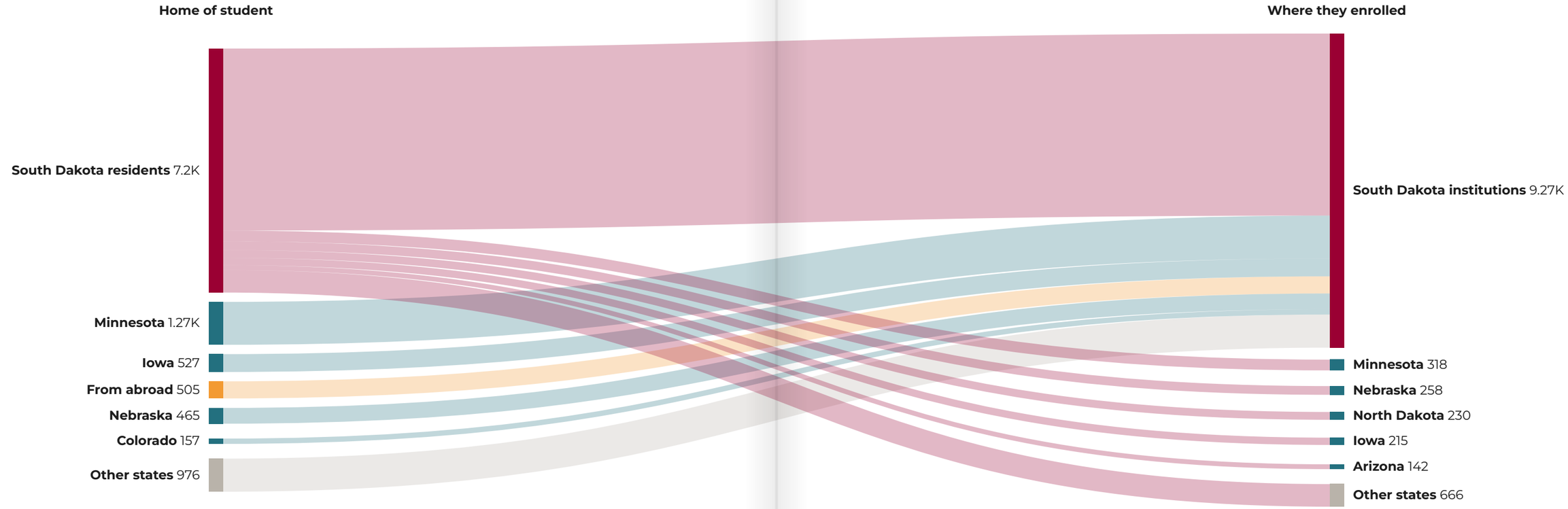
STEM master's per STEM research doctorate (IPEDS), 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **17th** of 51 · +1.2 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

South Dakota ranks 4th of 51 on the share of first-time students whose home is outside the US, at 5.4% in 2024 against 3.1% for the U.S.

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations (more when states tie at the printed figure), the rest grouped; ties are ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

5.37K residents stayed in South Dakota for college in fall 2024; 3.39K students arrived from other states and 505 from abroad, while 1.83K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 58% of the state's first-time students are residents.

58%

First-time students from in state, 2024

45th of 51 · −4.0 pp since 2016

5.4%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

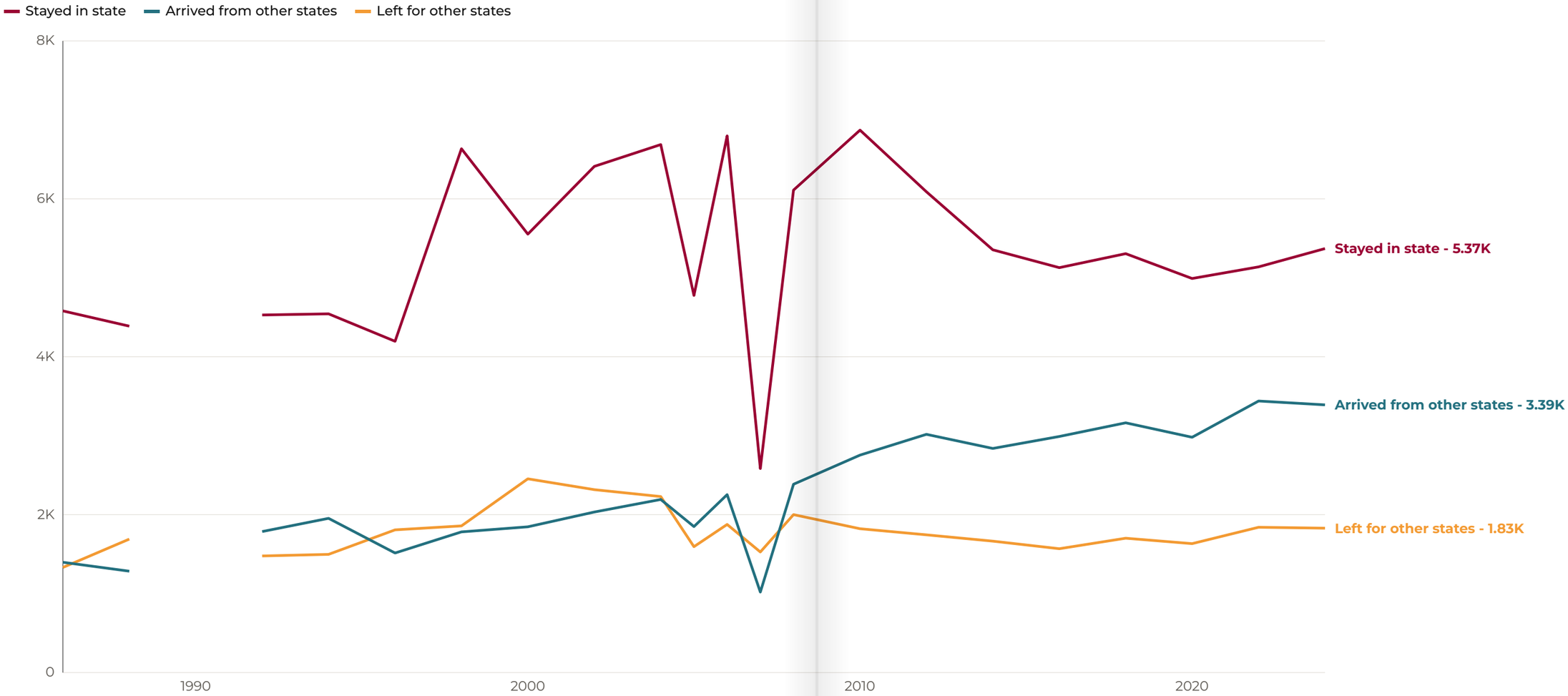
U.S. **3.1%** · **4th** of 51 · +3.7 pp since 2016

+22

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

12th of 51 · +0.5 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is up 5%, arrivals from other states are up 13%, and residents leaving are up 17%.

Net migration was +22 per 100 resident first-time students (12th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Minnesota (318).

Figure 12

Where Do South Dakota's Newcomers Come From?

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at South Dakota's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

3.9K

First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024

Abroad **505**

5.4%

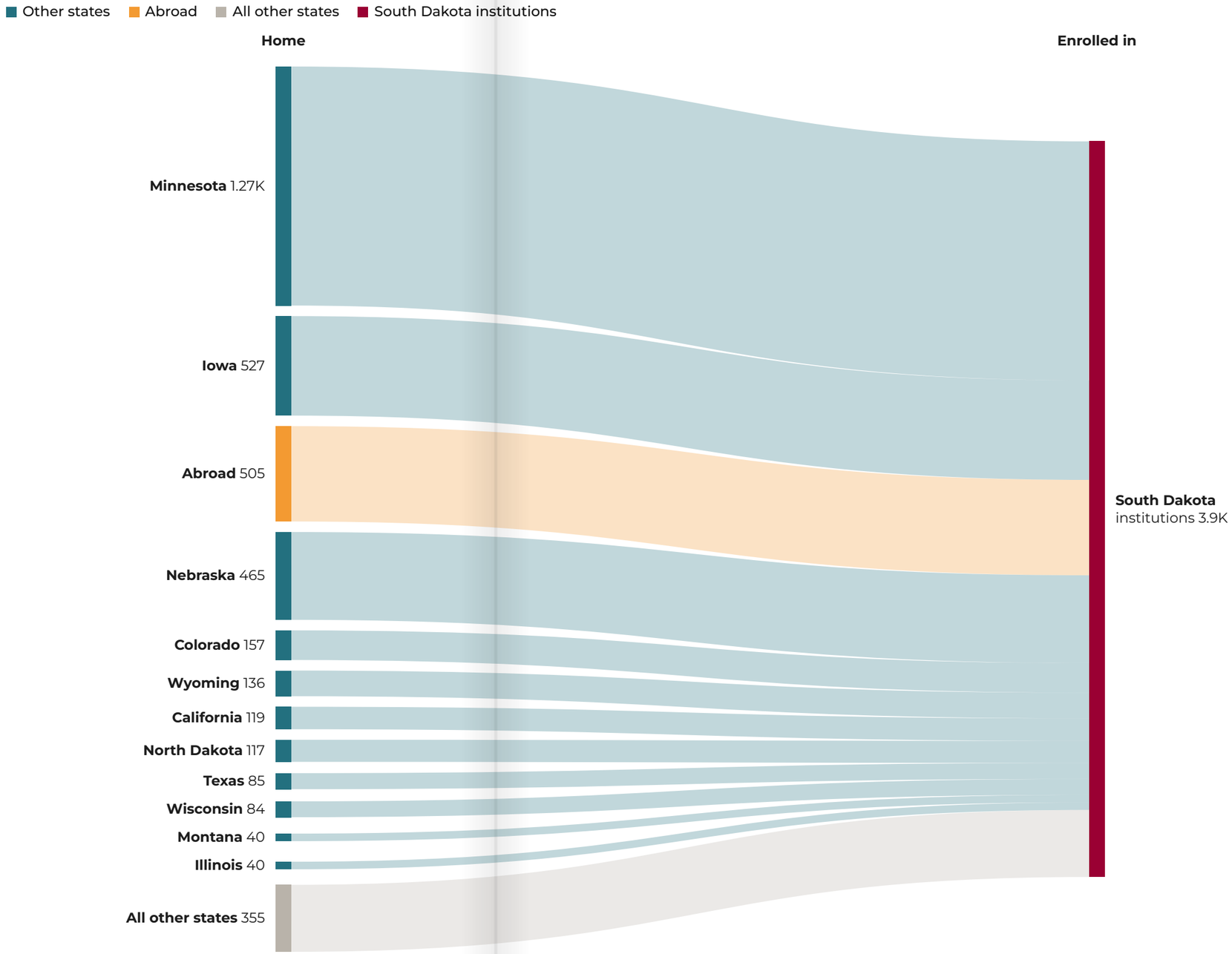
First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **4th** of 51 · +3.7 pp since 2016

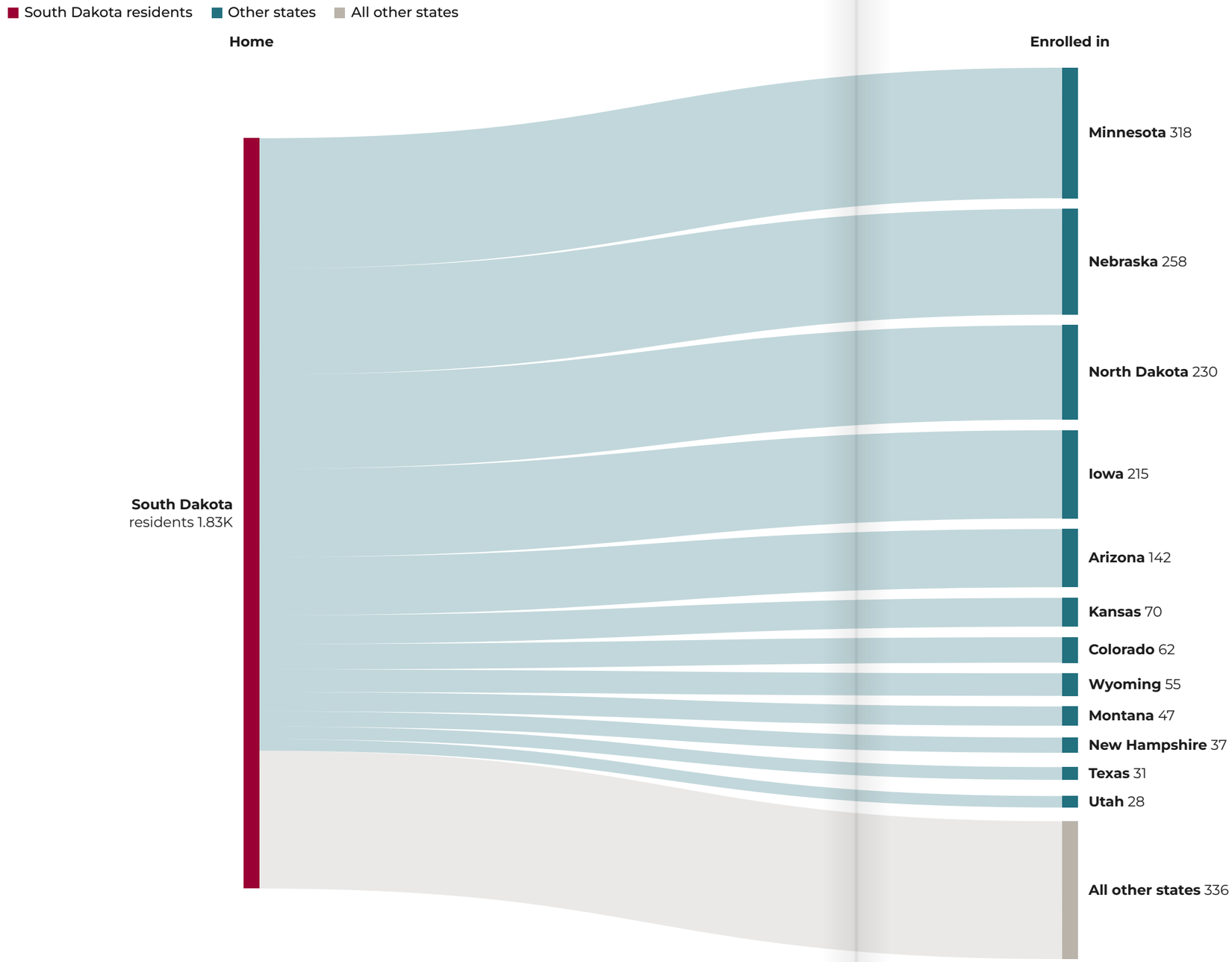
58%

First-time students from in state, 2024

45th of 51 · −4.0 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows (more when states tie at the printed figure), ordered by exact count. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Figure 13

Where Do South Dakota's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where South Dakota residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. The number was 1.83K in fall 2024, down 0.6% from 1.84K in fall 2022 and up 17% since fall 2016, when it was 1.57K.

1.83K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrived from other states **3.39K** · **3.9K** with abroad

+22
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
12th of 51 · +0.5 since 2016

318
Went to Minnesota
The largest destination

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

South Dakota ranks 6th of 51 on the average grade 8 mathematics score, at 281 in 2024 against 272 for the U.S.

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are South Dakota's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. South Dakota's eighth graders averaged 281 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 6th of 51 among the states.

33% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

281

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **6th** of 51 · −3.5 since 2015

33%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **6th** of 51 · −0.4 pp since 2015

260

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

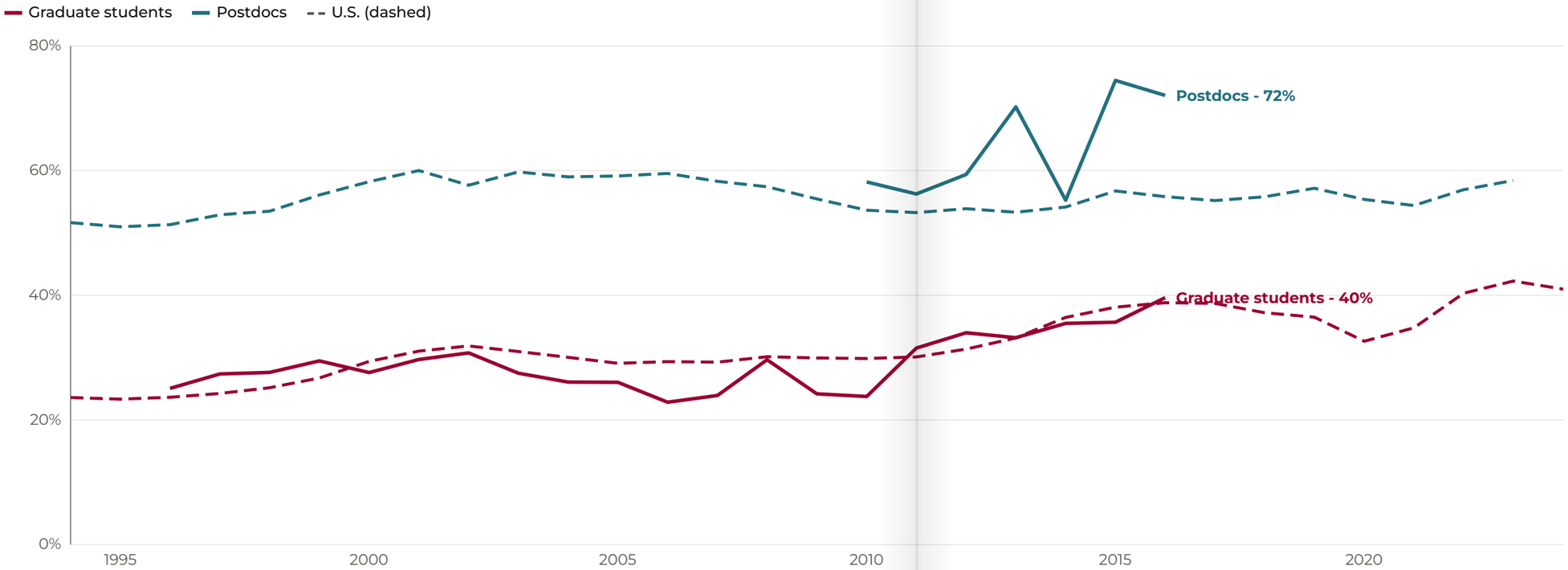
U.S. **257** · **16th** of 51 · −7.2 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

South Dakota ranks 1st of 51 on the temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs, at 72% in 2016 against 56% for the U.S.

Figure 15 How Many of South Dakota's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 40% of South Dakota's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 14th of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 72% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 135 research doctorates in 2025, 0.2% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

40%
S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **39%** · **14th** of 51 · +3.9 pp since 2015

72%
S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016
U.S. **56%** · **1st** of 51 · −2.4 pp since 2015

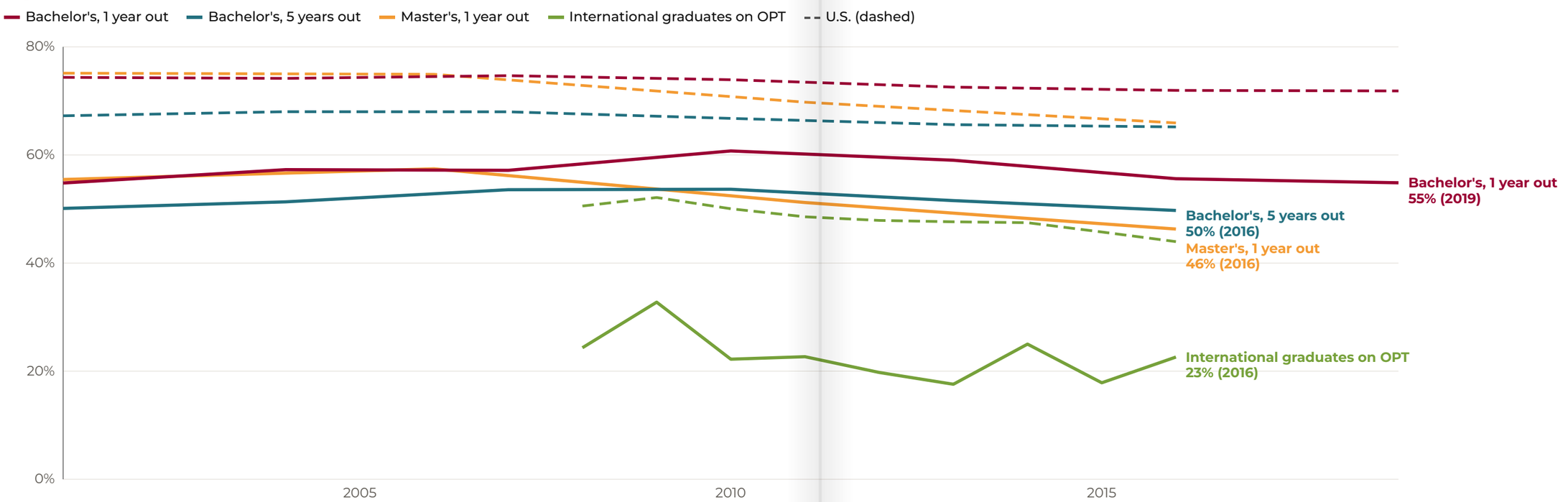
135
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025
U.S. **59K** · **47th** of 51 · +23% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

South Dakota ranks 50th of 51 on net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents, at −14.1 in 2025.

Figure 16 How Many of South Dakota's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Of South Dakota's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 55% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 50%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 23% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). That is the last year the released records cover, before most of the growth in international STEM master's degrees since 2015. Through migration between states, the state lost 14.1 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

55%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **28th** of 33 · −0.8 pp since 2016

23%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **45th** of 51 · +4.8 pp since 2015

−14.1

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

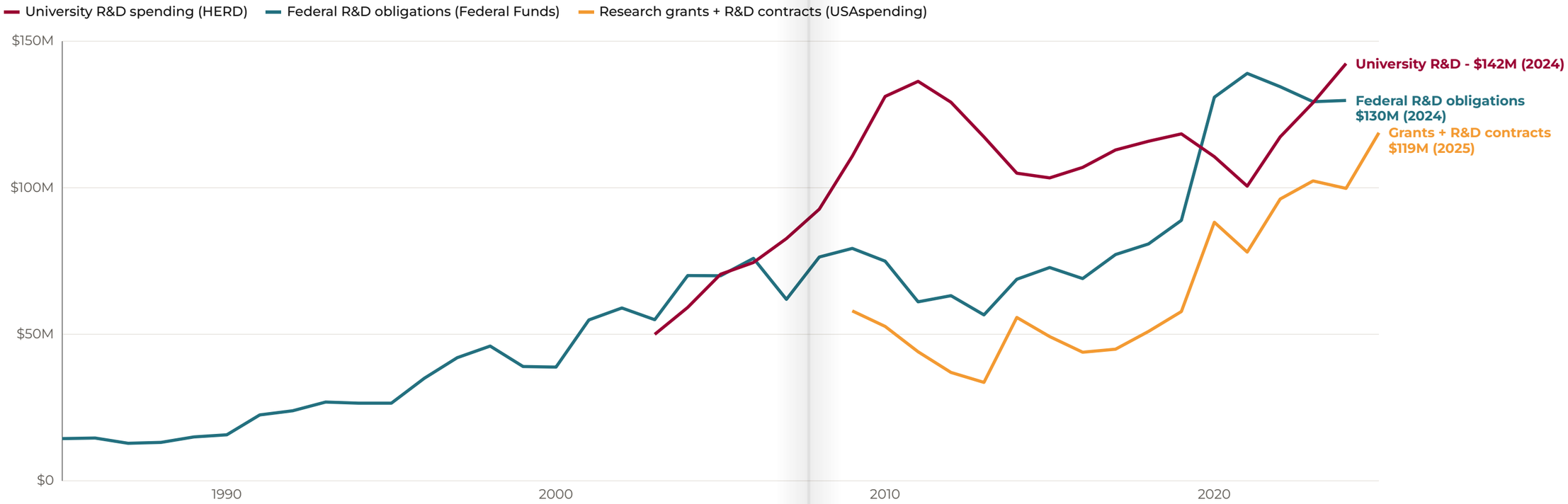
50th of 51 · −3.9 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

South Dakota ranks 51st of 51 on university R&D spending, at $142M in 2024 against $118B for the U.S.

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into South Dakota?



Nominal dollars (not adjusted for inflation), fiscal years; a line ending before the others is labeled with its last year. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

South Dakota's universities spent $142M on research and development in FY2024, 51st of 51 among the states; 51% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $130M for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$142M

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **51st** of 51 · +38% since 2015

51%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **30th** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

$130M

Federal R&D obligations, 2024

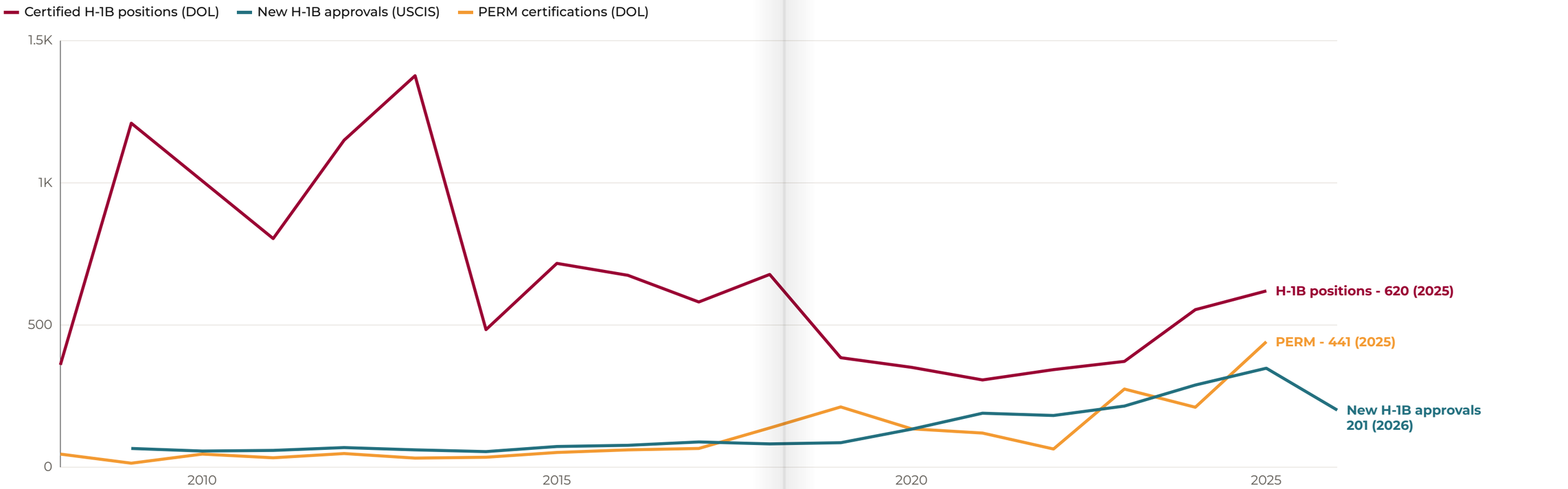
U.S. **$193B** · **50th** of 51 · +78% since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

South Dakota ranks 3rd of 51 on the share of PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas, at 20% in 2024 against 8.7% for the U.S.

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does South Dakota Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 620 H-1B positions at South Dakota worksites in FY2025, 45th of 51 among the states. A labor condition application comes before the petition and covers renewals and job changes as well as new hires, by the worksite's state, so it runs well above approvals. USCIS approved 201 new H-1B petitions in FY2026 and 762 continuing ones, counted by the employer's address.

DOL certified 441 PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 20% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

620

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **45th** of 51 · −14% since 2015

441

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

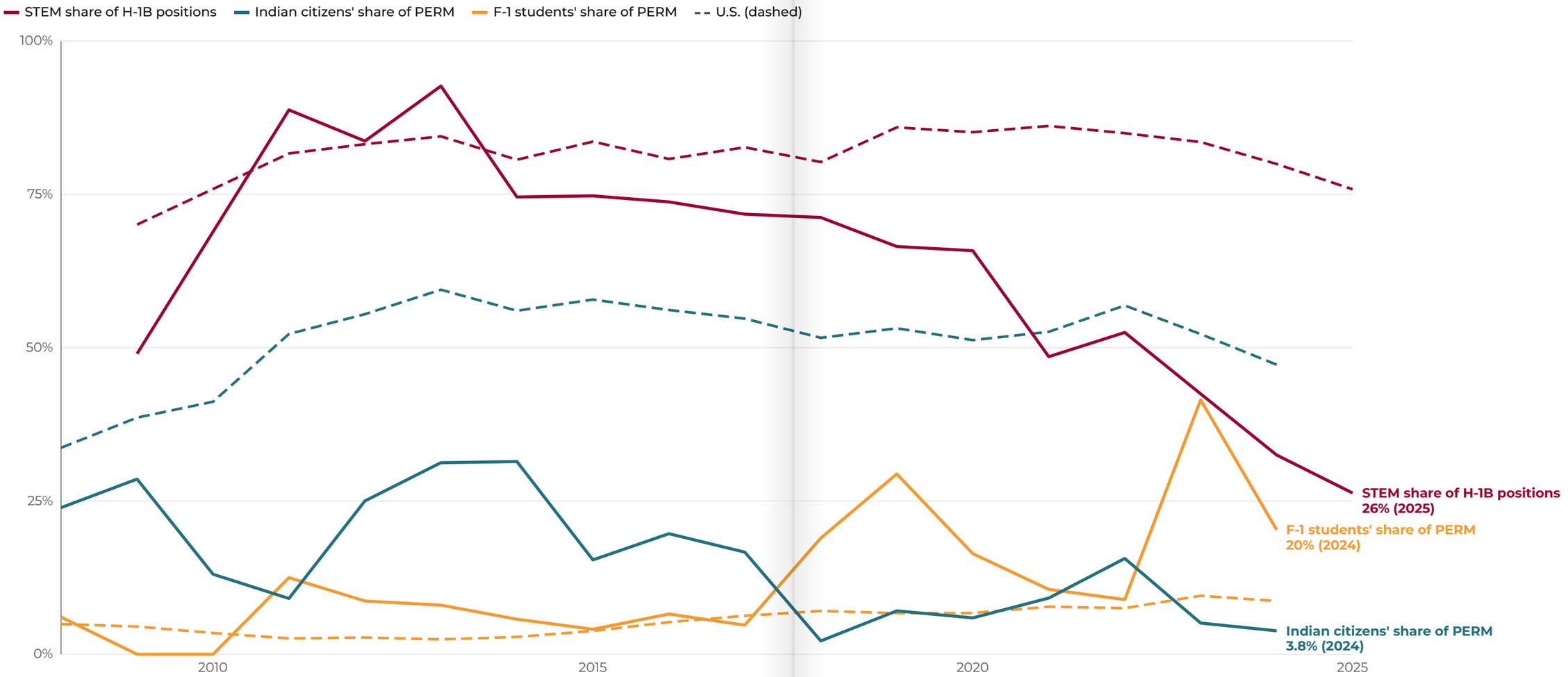
U.S. **138K** · **37th** of 51 · 8.48× since 2015

20%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **3rd** of 51 · +16.2 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds South Dakota's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

26% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 3.8% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

26%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **47th** of 51 · −48.5 pp since 2015

3.8%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **48th** of 51 · −11.6 pp since 2015

$69.1K

Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

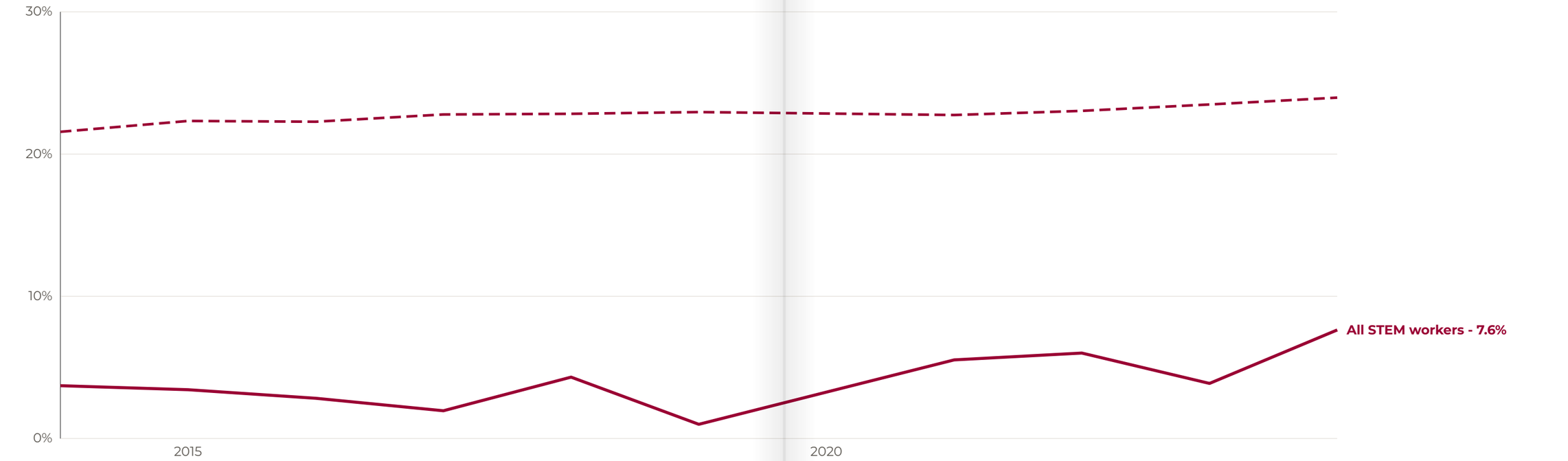
U.S. **$119K** · **51st** of 51 · +6.8% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

South Dakota ranks 48th of 51 on the noncitizen share of STEM workers, at 2.8% in 2024 against 11% for the U.S.

Figure 20 How Much of South Dakota's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 7.6% of the people working in STEM occupations in South Dakota were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 44th of 51).

7.6%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **44th** of 51 · +4.2 pp since 2015

2.8%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

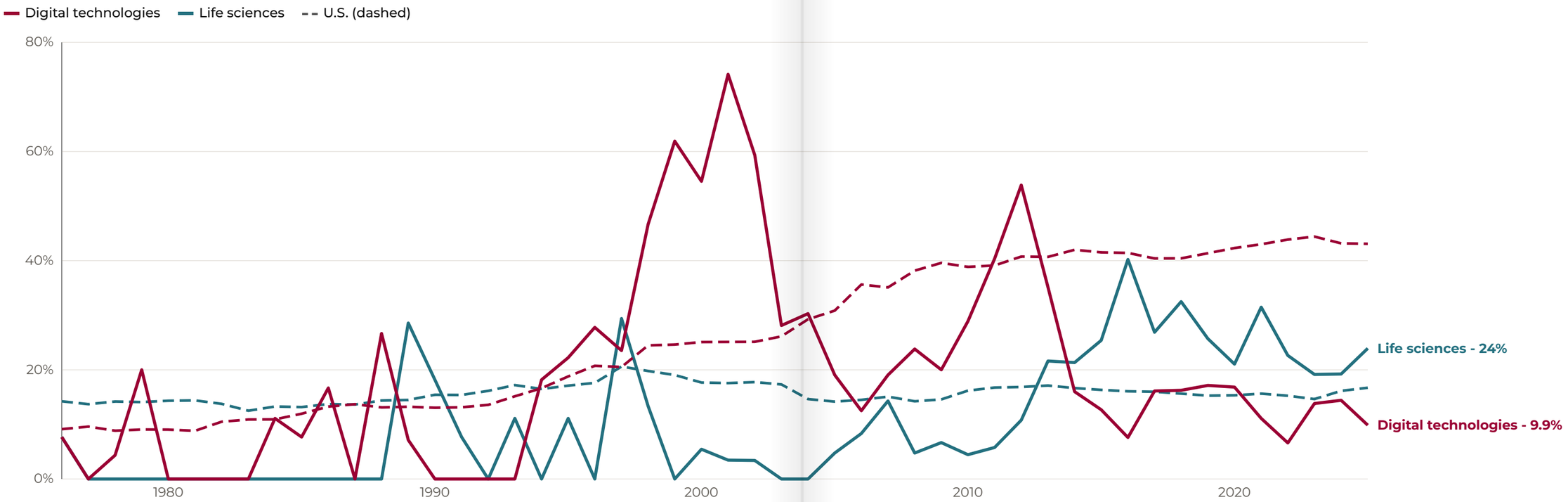
U.S. **11%** · **48th** of 51 · +0.3 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

South Dakota ranks 47th of 51 on patents granted to assignees in the state, at 71 in 2025 against 135K for the U.S.

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does South Dakota Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in South Dakota were granted 71 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.1% of all patents with a U.S. owner (47th of 51).

9.9% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 24% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

71

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **47th** of 51 · +16% since 2015

9.9%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **41st** of 51 · −2.8 pp since 2015

24%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

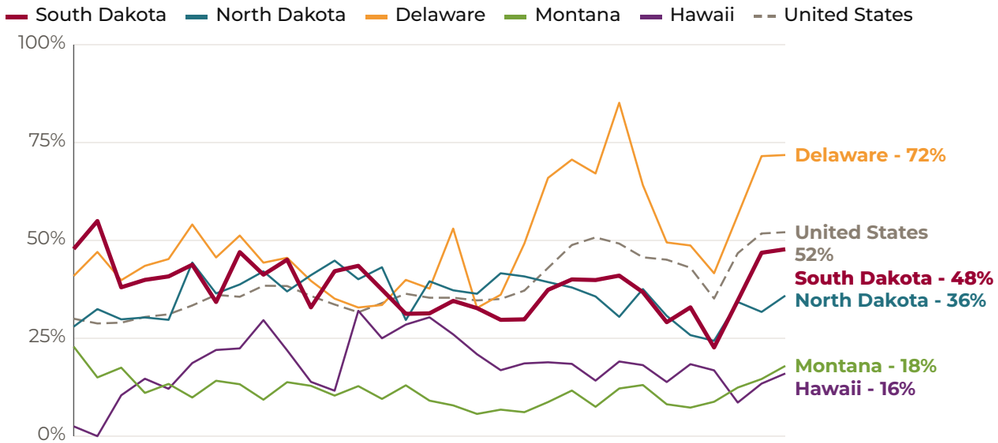
U.S. **17%** · **14th** of 51 · −1.5 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally (a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size), are North Dakota, Delaware, Montana, and Hawaii. South Dakota ranks 2nd of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Delaware is the most dependent at 72%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are South Dakota and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



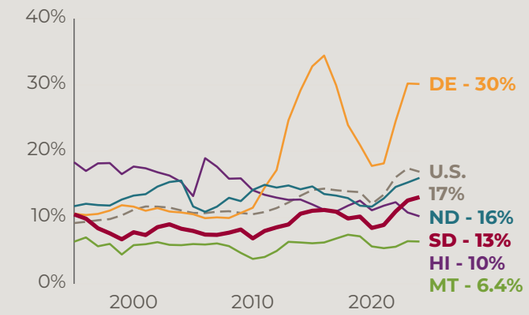
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Table 4 How Does South Dakota Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	SD	ND	DE	MT	HI	U.S.
Students enrolled, 2024	**54.2K**	53.5K	57.8K	48.4K	61.4K	19.7M
Graduate share of students, 2024	**17%**	15%	18%	12%	12%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025	**26%**	21%	22%	32%	20%	24%
STEM share of master's, 2025	**27%**	18%	38%	22%	17%	23%
International STEM master's, 2025	**277**	122	1.03K	56	40	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025	**0.2%**	0.1%	0.9%	0.0%	0.0%	–
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025	**48%**	36%	72%	18%	16%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates, 2025	**40%**	57%	52%	12%	35%	43%
Int. share of grad students, 2024	**13%**	16%	30%	6.4%	10%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment, 2024	**3.4%**	2.7%	3.5%	1.1%	6.2%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024	**58%**	60%	72%	52%	56%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023	**$9.25K**	$9.87K	$11.8K	$7.93K	$10.4K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student, 2024	**$9.61K**	$11.9K	$8.9K	$9.29K	$16.9K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary, 2024	**$79.3K**	$82.6K	$123K	$82K	$110K	$106K
First-time students from in state, 2024	**58%**	50%	58%	58%	73%	–
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024	**+22**	+42	+7	+21	−21	–

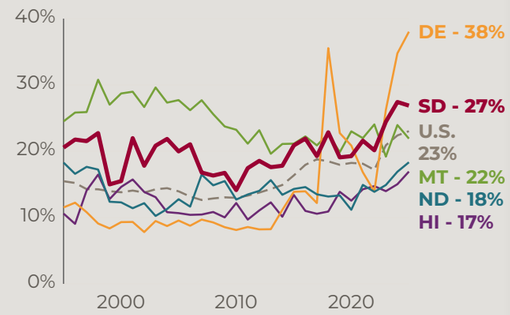
Latest year for each measure, given after its name. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



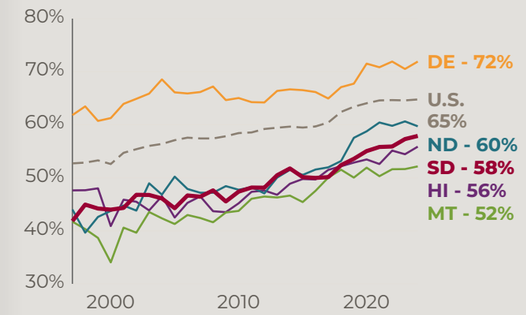
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



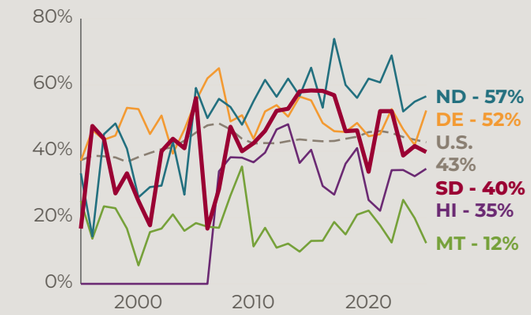
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM doctorates

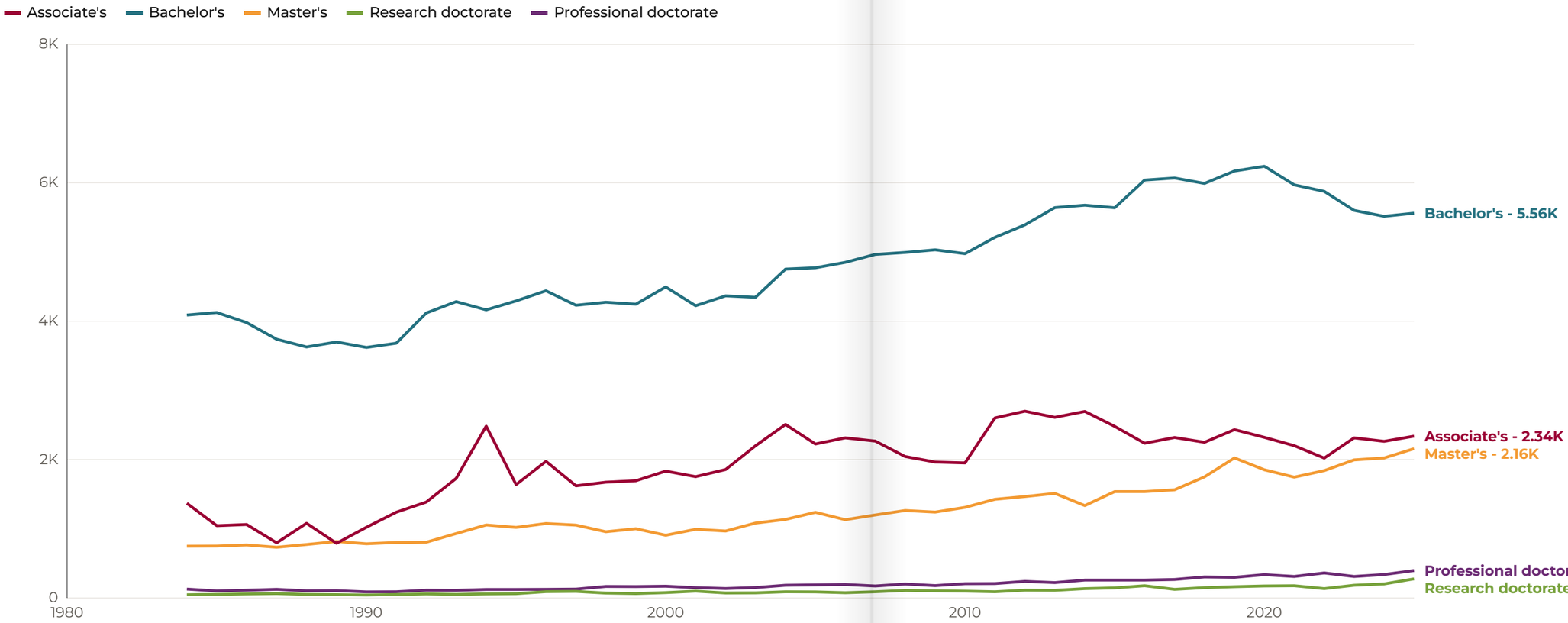


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does South Dakota Award?



Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, South Dakota's institutions awarded 2.34K associate's degrees, 5.56K bachelor's degrees, 2.16K master's degrees, 277 research doctorate degrees, 397 professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's down 6%; bachelor's roughly flat; master's up 40%; research doctorate up 88%; professional doctorate up 53%. The state awards 12.3 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

Figure 28 What Do South Dakota's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Dakota's largest bachelor's fields are health professions (17%; U.S. 13%), business (14%; U.S. 19%), education (9.3%; U.S. 4.3%).

Relative to the nation, South Dakota's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in agriculture (4.41× the U.S. share), education (2.16× the U.S. share), parks & recreation (1.99× the U.S. share).

6.3%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **20th** of 51 · +3.0 pp since 2015

8.1%

Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025

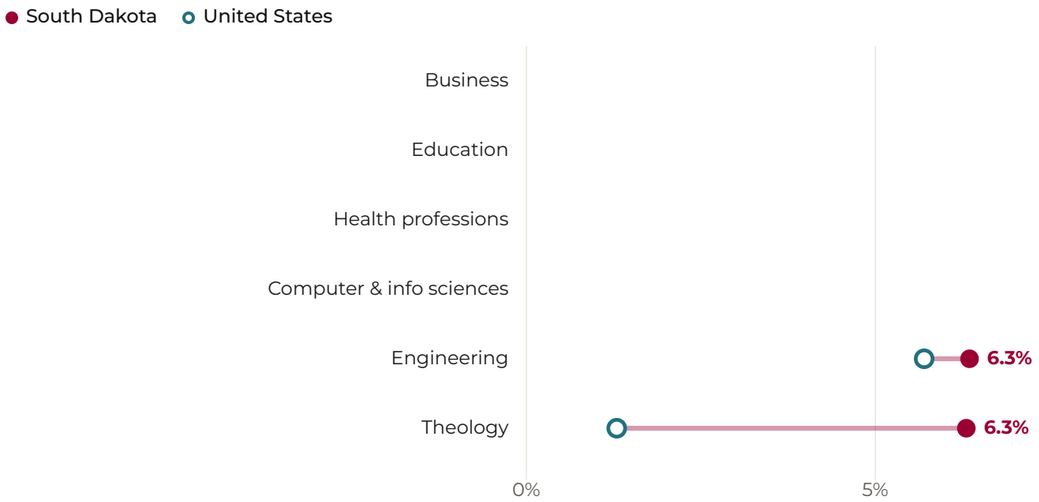
U.S. **6.8%** · **11th** of 51 · +1.4 pp since 2015

14%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **48th** of 51 · +1.6 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do South Dakota's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Dakota's largest master's fields are business (20%; U.S. 21%), education (16%; U.S. 15%), health professions (14%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 18% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 27% of them.

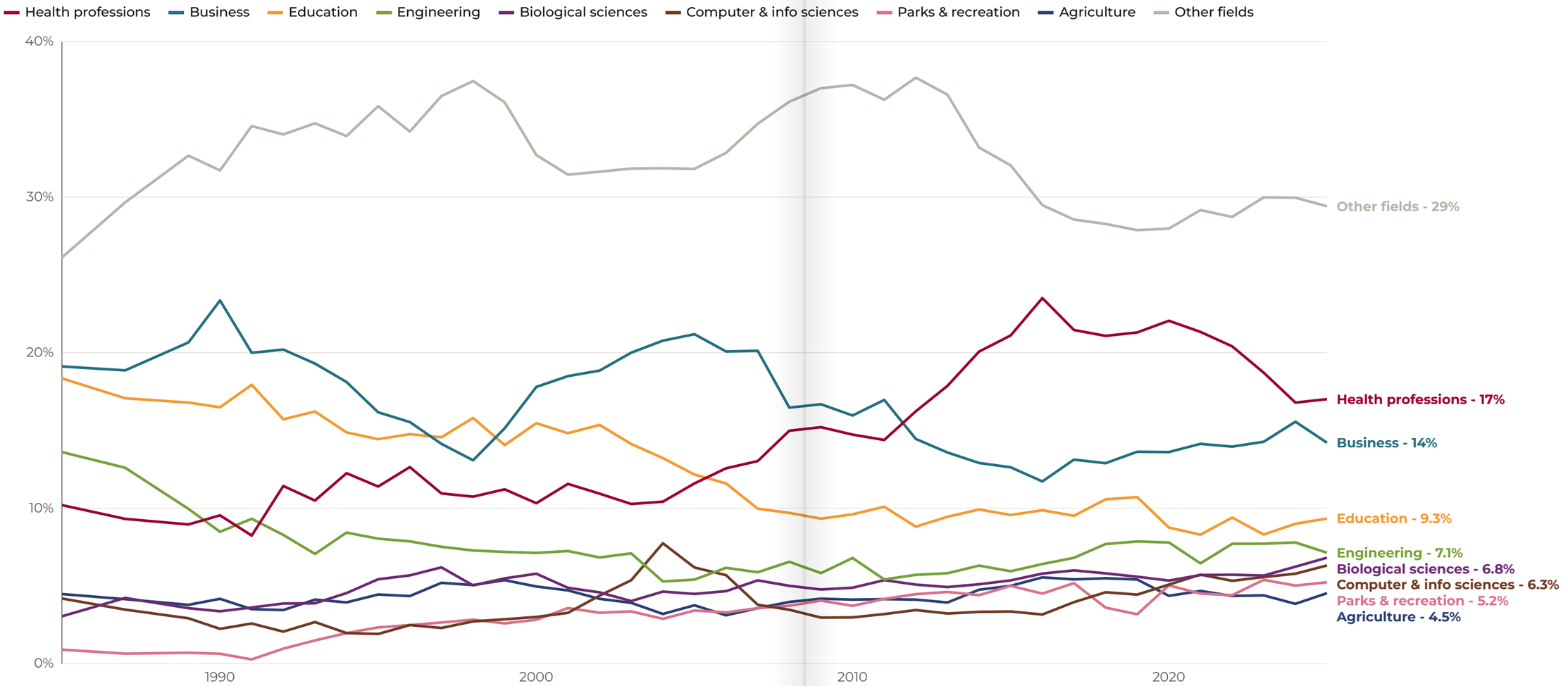
27%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **10th** of 51 · +6.0 pp since 2015

18%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **23rd** of 51 · +7.8 pp since 2015

70%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **19th** of 47 · +18.2 pp since 2015

12

Figure 30 How Has South Dakota's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, computer & info sciences has gained the most ground, 3.0 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while health professions lost the most (4.1 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

SECTION 12 · FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is South Dakota Most Specialized?

The location quotient divides a field's share of South Dakota's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Agriculture (4.41, with 4.5% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 1.0% for the U.S.), education (2.16, with 9.3% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 4.3% for the U.S.), and parks & recreation (1.99, with 5.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 2.6% for the U.S.) had the highest quotients.

Table 5 Where Is South Dakota Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Agriculture	**4.41**	4.5%	1.0%	252
Education	**2.16**	9.3%	4.3%	519
Parks & recreation	**1.99**	5.2%	2.6%	291
Health professions	**1.36**	17%	13%	946
Liberal arts	**1.22**	2.2%	1.8%	123
Engineering	**1.22**	7.1%	5.9%	397
Biological sciences	**1.04**	6.8%	6.6%	379
Computer & info sciences	**0.92**	6.3%	6.9%	351
Business	**0.75**	14%	19%	790
Security & protective	**0.74**	1.9%	2.6%	105

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

26%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **15th** of 51

6.3%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **20th** of 51

8.1%
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **11th** of 51

Engineering & eng. technology. The share was 8.1% in 2025, against 6.8% for the U.S., 11th among the states, down 0.2 points from 8.4% in 2024 and up 1.4 points since 2015, when it was 6.8%.

Health professions. The share was 17% in 2025, against 12% for the U.S., 7th among the states, up 0.2 points from 17% in 2024 and down 4.1 points since 2015, when it was 21%.

Table 6 South Dakota at a Glance

Measure	2015	Previous	Latest	Change	U.S.	Rank
STEM share of bachelor's	19%	24% 2024	**26% 2025**	+6.7 pp	24%	15th
Bachelor's in computer science	3.4%	5.8% 2024	**6.3% 2025**	+3.0 pp	6.9%	20th
Bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	6.8%	8.4% 2024	**8.1% 2025**	+1.4 pp	6.8%	11th
Bachelor's in business	13%	16% 2024	**14% 2025**	+1.6 pp	19%	48th

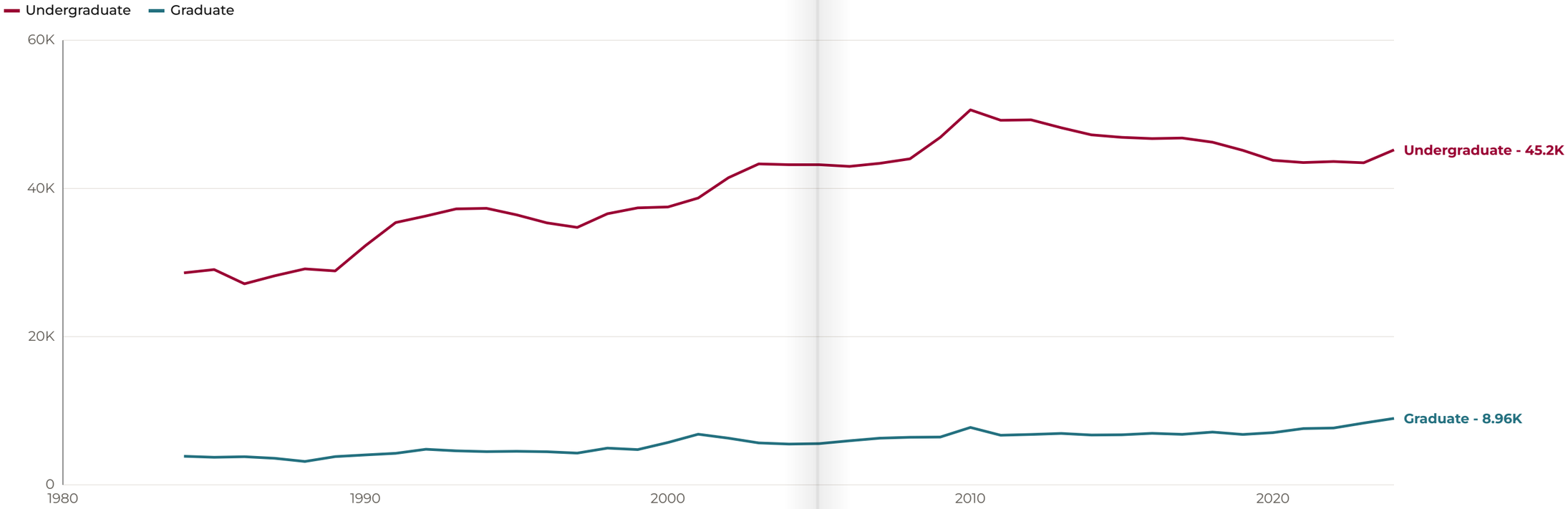
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 13

Students and Money

South Dakota ranks 46th of 51 on fall enrollment, at 54.2K in 2024 against 19.7M for the U.S.

Figure 31 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, South Dakota enrolled 45.2K undergraduates and 8.96K graduate students, 54.2K in all (46th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is down 4% since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 33% since 2015. Graduate students are 17% of all students (U.S. 17%).

54.2K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **46th** of 51 · +0.9% since 2015

17%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **20th** of 51 · +3.9 pp since 2015

40%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **23rd** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

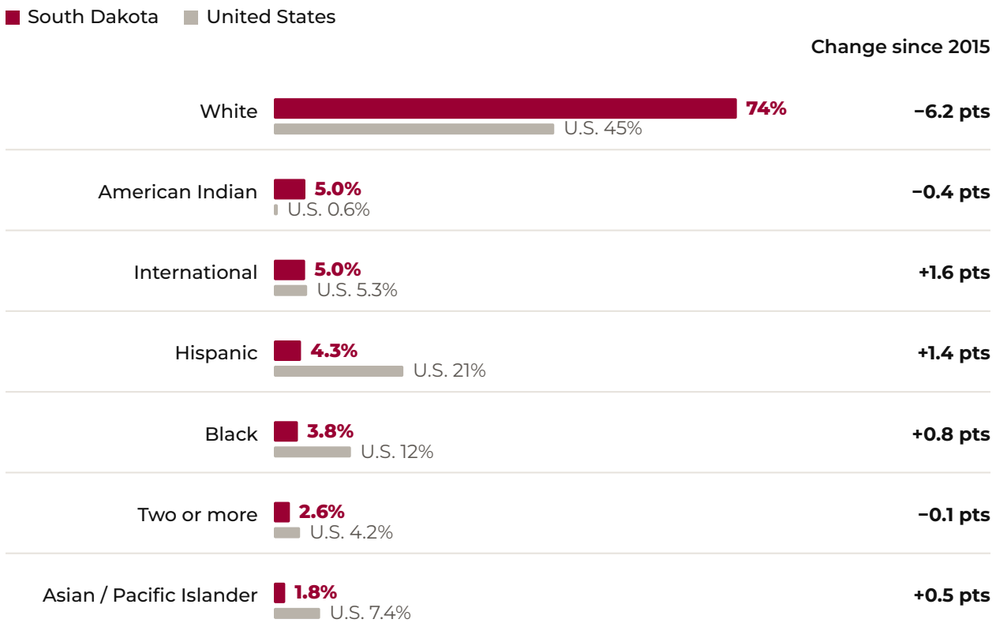
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

Who Enrolls in South Dakota, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at South Dakota's degree-granting institutions, **74%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 6.2 points since 2015.

American Indian students were **5.0%** (U.S. 0.6%), down 0.4 points since 2015, and International students were **5.0%** (U.S. 5.3%), up 1.6 points since 2015.

Figure 32 Who Enrolls in South Dakota?



Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

74%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −6.2 pp since 2015

5.0%
American Indian students
U.S. **0.6%** · −0.4 pp since 2015

70%
At public 4-year institutions
−0.8 pp since 2015

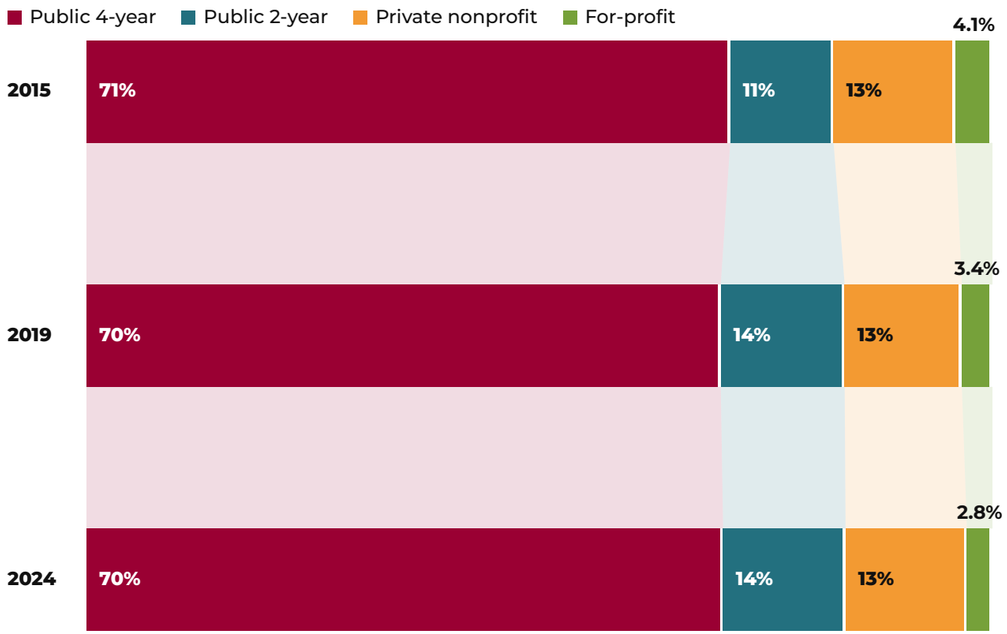
14%
At public 2-year institutions
+2.1 pp since 2015

In fall 2024, public 4-year institutions enrolled **70%** of students, down 0.8 points from 71% in 2015. Public 2-year institutions enrolled **14%** of students, up 2.1 points from 11% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **13%** of students, down 0.1 points from 13% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled **2.8%** of students, down 1.3 points from 4.1% in 2015.

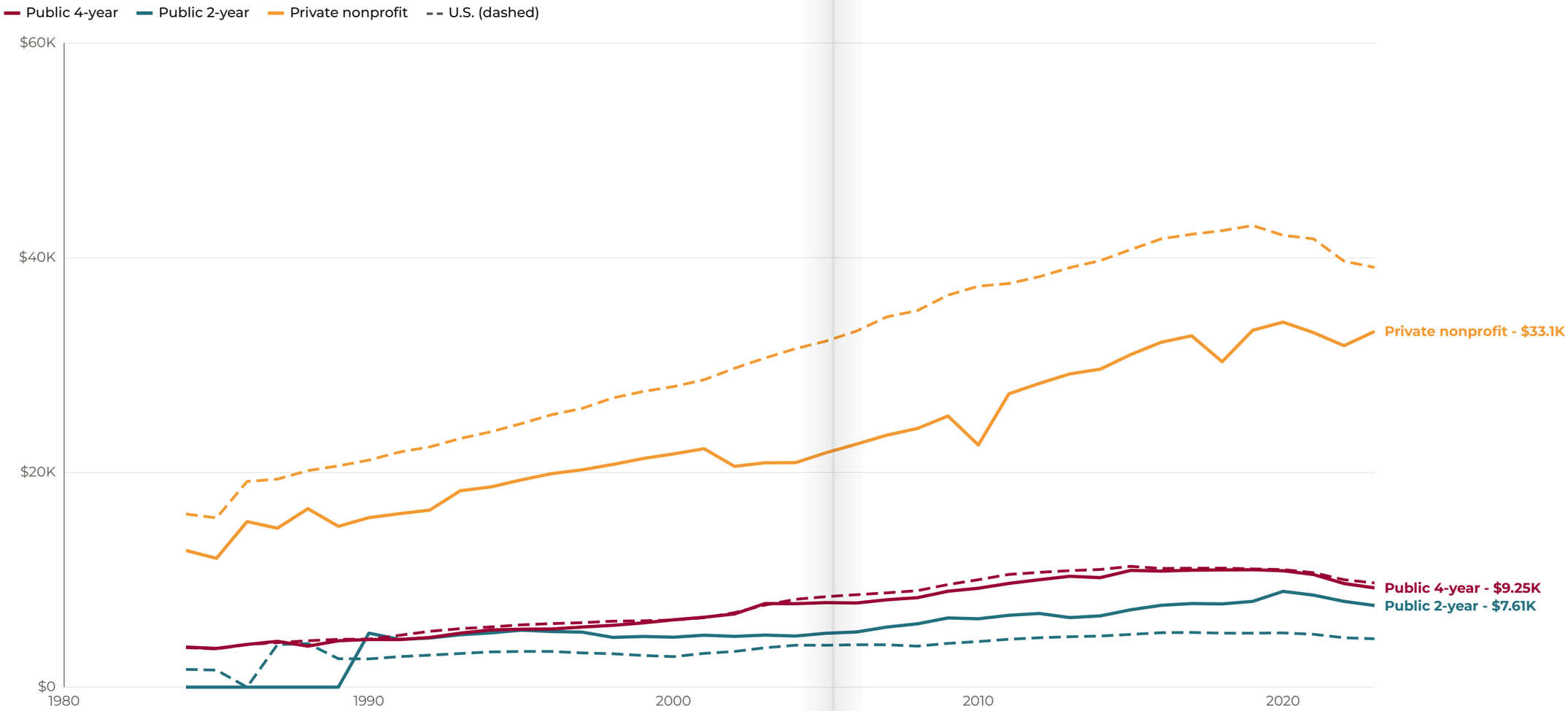
Public institutions together enrolled **84%** of students, against 73% nationally, 17th among the states.

Figure 33 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Sectors as IPEDS classifies them each year. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 34 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at South Dakota's public four-year institutions are $9.25K (2023, 2024 dollars), 5% below the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 33rd of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $9.61K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (35th of 51), and net tuition makes up 45% of net tuition plus state and local appropriations (U.S. 43%).

$9.25K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **33rd** of 51 · −15% since 2015

$9.61K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **35th** of 51 · +28% since 2015

45%

Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **28th** of 51 · −11.5 pp since 2015

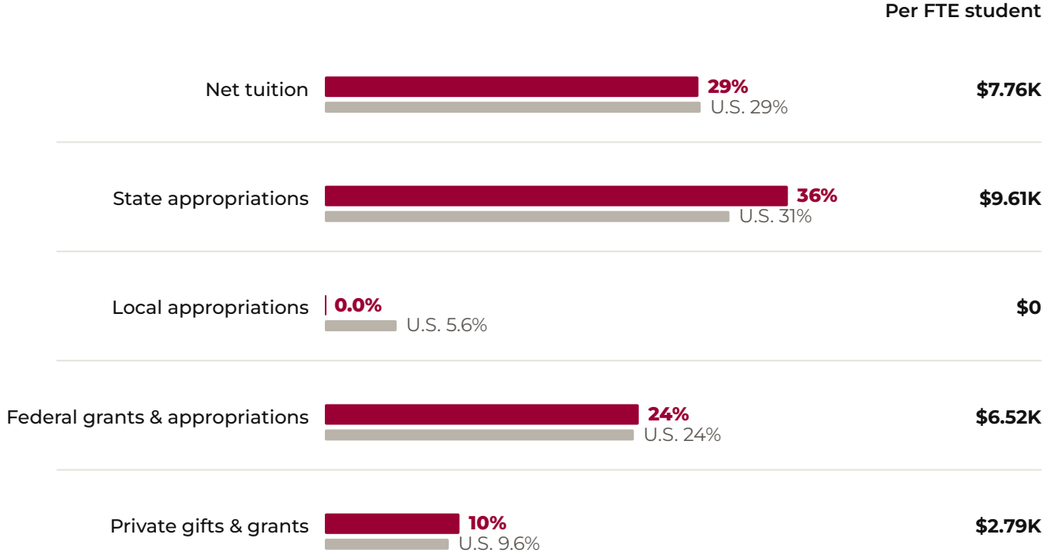
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are South Dakota's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of South Dakota's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. The figure was $7.76K in FY2024, against $8.96K for the U.S., down 3.1% from $8K in FY2023 and down 20% since FY2015, when it was $9.67K.

Figure 35 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Shares are of all five sources; the tuition share elsewhere in this profile divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations only. Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$9.25K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **33rd** of 51

$9.61K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **35th** of 51

45%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **28th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in South Dakota: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. The figure was $9.25K in 2023, against $9.71K for the U.S., 33rd among the states, down 4.2% from $9.66K in 2022 and down 15% since 2015, when it was $10.9K.

Table 7 Money and Results

Measure	Year	South Dakota	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$9.25K**	$9.71K	33rd of 51	−15%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$9.61K**	$11.4K	35th of 51	+28%
Tuition share of tuition plus appropriations	2024	**45%**	43%	28th of 51	−11.5 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**58%**	65%	40th of 51	+7.8 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$79.3K**	$106K	47th of 51	−7.6%

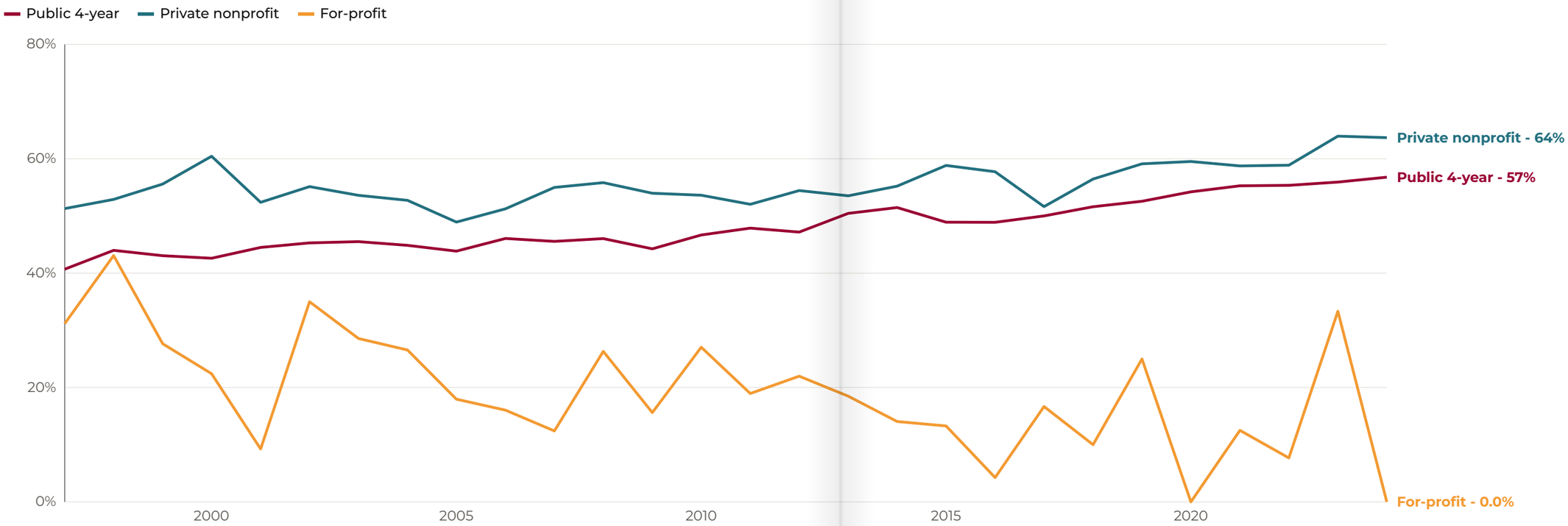
Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

South Dakota ranks 3rd of 50 on the share of completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions, at 67% in 2024 against 41% for the U.S.

Figure 36 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in South Dakota graduated within six years (2024), 6.9 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 40th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 57%, private nonprofit 64%, for-profit 0.0%. At two-year institutions, 67% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **40th** of 51 · +7.8 pp since 2015

67%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **3rd** of 50 · +7.0 pp since 2015

12.3
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **31st** of 51 · +0.4 since 2015

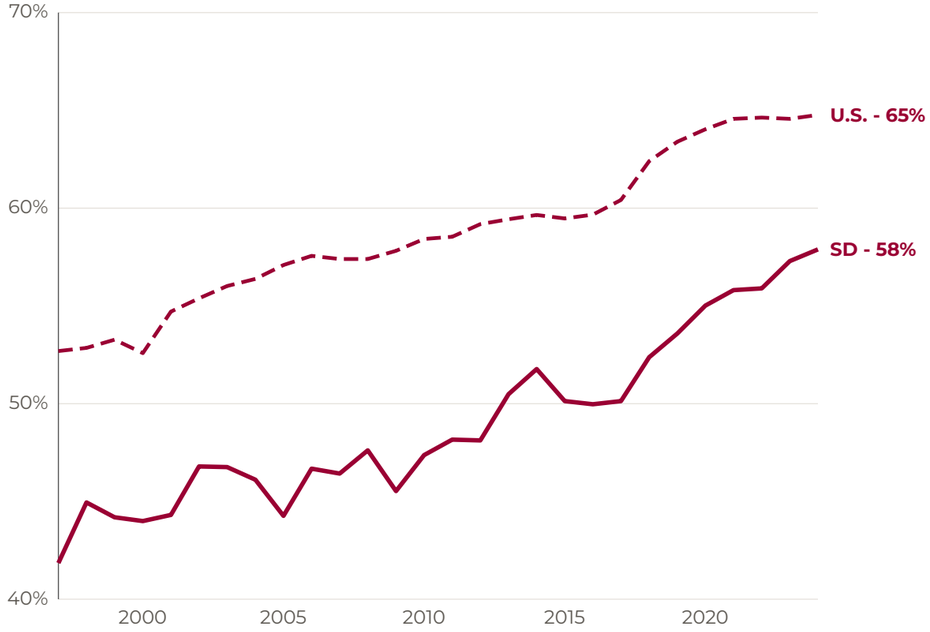
SECTION 14 · STUDENT OUTCOMES

How Many of South Dakota's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at South Dakota's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The rate leaves out students who start part-time (40% of the state's students attend part-time, against 39% nationally) and students who transfer and finish elsewhere. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. The rate was 58% in 2024, against 65% for the U.S., up 0.6 points from 57% in 2023 and up 7.8 points since 2015, when it was 50%.

Figure 37 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **40th** of 51

67%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **3rd** of 50

12.3
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **31st** of 51

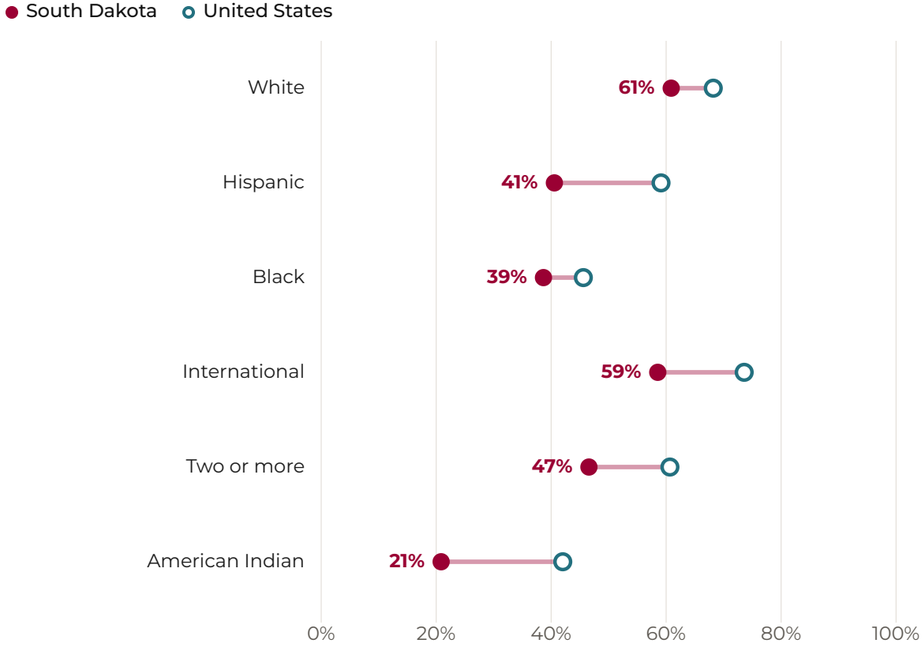
Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at South Dakota's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. The six-year rate was 61% in 2024, against 68% for the U.S.

Hispanic. The six-year rate was 41% in 2024, against 59% for the U.S.

Black. The six-year rate was 39% in 2024, against 46% for the U.S.

Figure 38 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



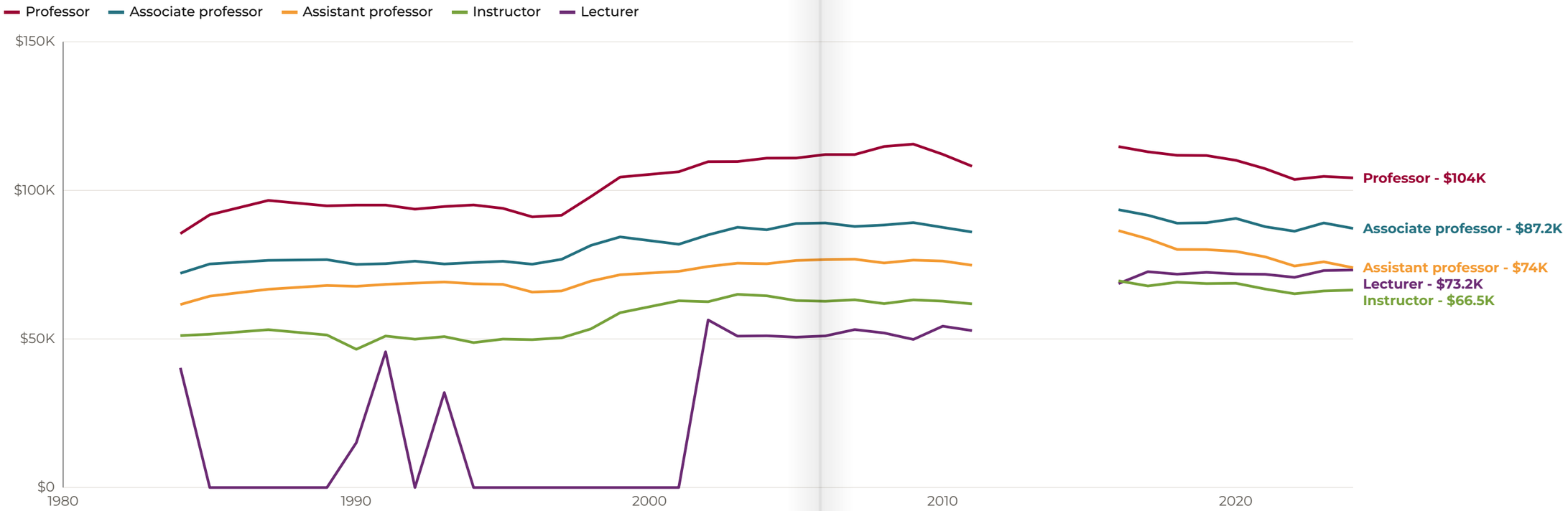
Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 15

Faculty

South Dakota ranks 47th of 51 on the average full-time faculty salary, at $79.3K in 2024 against $106K for the U.S.

Figure 39 What Do South Dakota's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at South Dakota's institutions earned an average of $79.3K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 25% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 47th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $104K, associate professors $87.2K, assistant professors $74K, instructors $66.5K, lecturers $73.2K.

South Dakota's institutions had 2.16K full-time instructional staff in 2024, down 3% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 8% since 2016.

$79.3K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **47th** of 51 · −7.6% since 2016

SECTION 15 · FACULTY

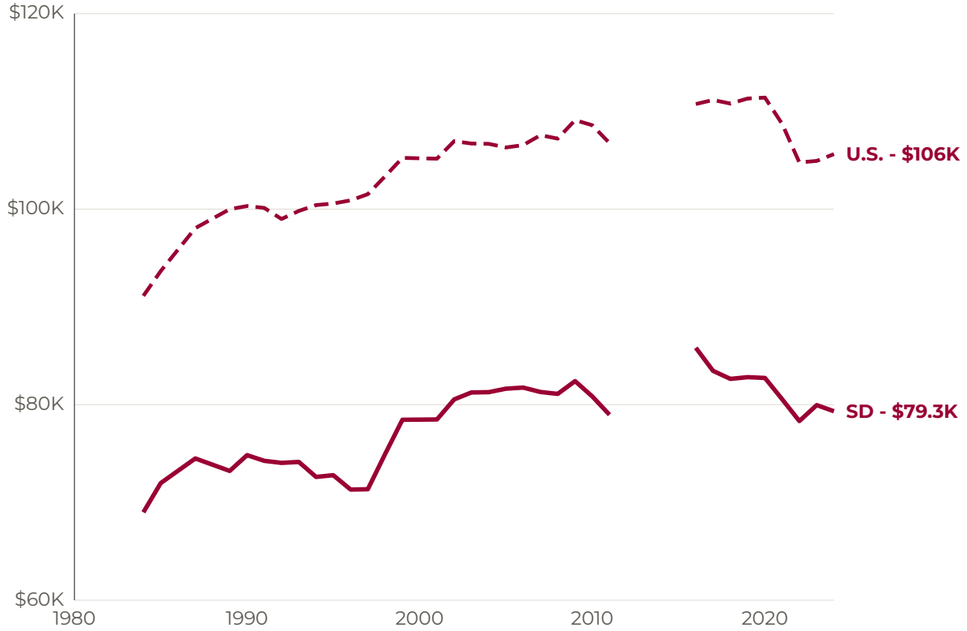
What Do South Dakota's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at South Dakota's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. The figure was $79.3K in 2024, against $106K for the U.S., 47th among the states, down 0.8% from $80K in 2023 and down 7.6% since 2016, when it was $85.8K.

Full-time instructional staff. The number was 2.16K in 2024, up 1.5% from 2.13K in 2023 and down 3.0% since 2015, when it was 2.23K.

Figure 40 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$79.3K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **47th** of 51

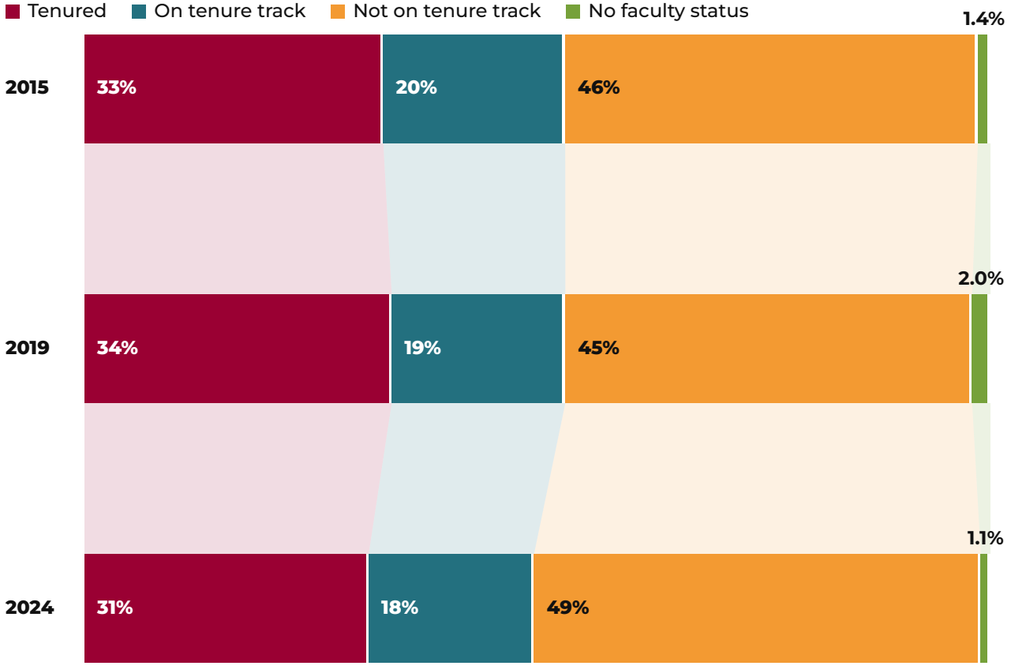
2.16K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

31%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide South Dakota's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. The share was 31% in 2024, down 0.7 points from 32% in 2023 and down 1.6 points since 2015, when it was 33%.

Figure 41 Tenure Status



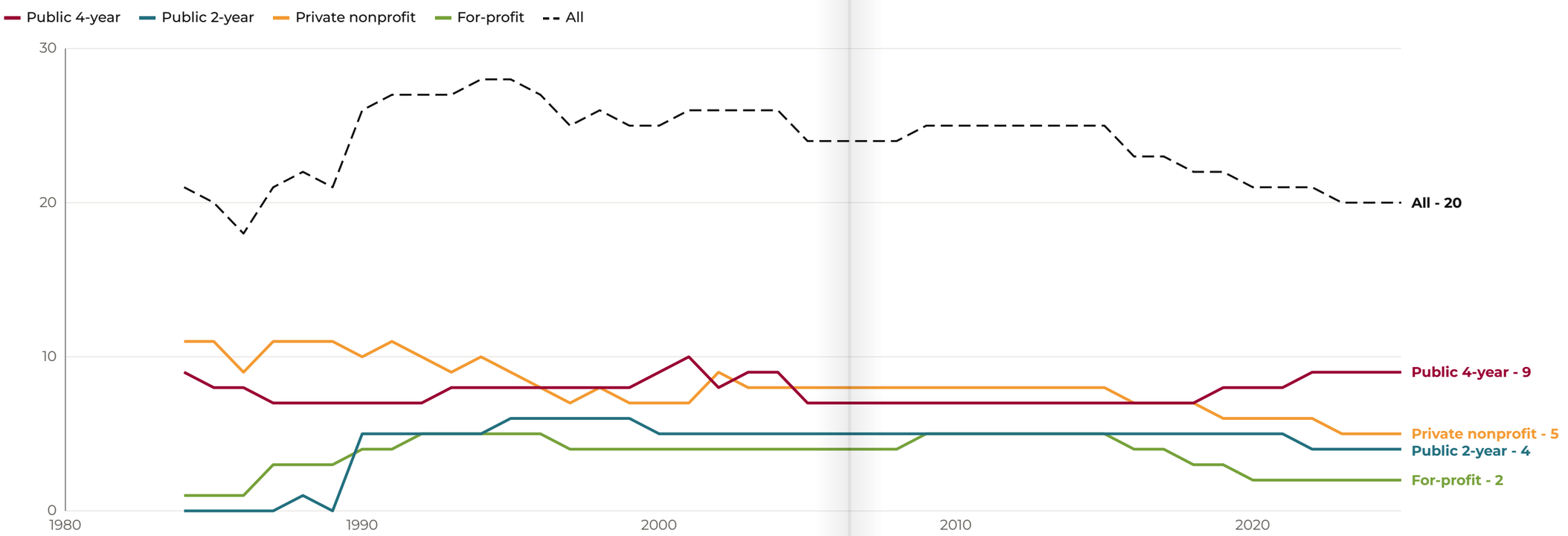
Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 16

Institutions

South Dakota ranks 10th of 51 on the share of students enrolled exclusively online, at 31% in 2024 against 27% for the U.S.

Figure 42 How Many Institutions Does South Dakota Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

South Dakota has 20 degree-granting institutions:9 public 4-year, 4 public 2-year, 5 private nonprofit, 2 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 20% since 2015. 84% of students attend public institutions and 2.8% attend for-profit ones.

84%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **17th** of 51 · +1.3 pp since 2015

2.8%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **21st** of 51 · −1.3 pp since 2015

31%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **10th** of 51 · +11.0 pp since 2015

SECTION 16 · INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in South Dakota?

The table ranks institutions in South Dakota by the STEM master's degrees and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025, the two counted together. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. University of South Dakota (152 international STEM master's degrees and 3 doctorates), South Dakota State University (59 international STEM master's degrees and 21 doctorates), and Dakota State University (38 international STEM master's degrees and – doctorates) awarded the most.

Table 8 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	STEM total	STEM master's	Int. share	STEM doctorates	Int. share
University of South Dakota Vermillion · Public 4-year	**155**	152	88%	3	33%
South Dakota State University Brookings · Public 4-year	**80**	59	46%	21	88%
Dakota State University Madison · Public 4-year	**38**	38	35%	–	–%
South Dakota School of Mines and Technology Rapid City · Public 4-year	**37**	26	20%	11	58%
Black Hills State University Spearfish · Public 4-year	**1**	1	33%	–	–
Mount Marty University Yankton · Private nonprofit	**1**	1	4.2%	–	–

Ranked by the total (shaded) of international STEM master's degrees and research doctorates. Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

20
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

84%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **17th** of 51

2.8%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **21st** of 51

31%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **10th** of 51

The table lists South Dakota's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. The three largest were South Dakota State University (12.1K students), University of South Dakota (10.6K students), and Dakota State University (3.77K students).

Degree-granting institutions. The state had 20 in 2025, and 20 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 9 What Are South Dakota's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
South Dakota State University	**12.1K**	32%	431	62%	98%
University of South Dakota	**10.6K**	14%	121	60%	99%
Dakota State University	**3.77K**	15%	236	49%	88%
Northern State University	**3.71K**	1.3%	48	55%	93%
Black Hills State University	**3.35K**	3.4%	46	43%	96%
Southeast Technical College	**2.66K**	–	–	–	–
South Dakota School of Mines and Technology	**2.58K**	31%	377	52%	80%
Augustana University	**2.39K**	3.6%	112	73%	68%
Lake Area Technical College	**2.31K**	–	–	–	–
University of Sioux Falls	**1.45K**	–	20	62%	83%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

Tuition, appropriations, revenue and faculty salaries are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Research funding (HERD, Federal Funds, USAspending), wages and the NAFSA economic contribution are nominal dollars, and are labeled so. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions; the tuition share divides net tuition by net tuition plus state and local appropriations.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts. Year-to-year comparisons use one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November).

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment, measured proportionally: a state 1.5 times as large counts as near as one two-thirds the size.

Sources

IPEDS (National Center for Education Statistics) is the backbone: Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. The profile also draws on NAEP, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates, Survey of Earned Doctorates, HERD and Federal Funds surveys, USAspending.gov, DHS SEVIS by the Numbers and ICE SEVIS releases, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification and BLS wage data, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes, USPTO PatentsView, and other federal sources; every figure names its source, and the Sources page lists them in full. Generated November 2026.

NOTES

How the Numbers Are Counted

Ranks

Ranks are among the 50 states and the District of Columbia (1 = highest value, whether or not a high value is good). Where fewer than 51 report, the count is given ("23rd of 33").

Sectors

Sectors are as IPEDS classifies institutions each year. IPEDS moves a whole institution to "public, 4-year or above" once it awards any bachelor's degree, so community colleges that began offering applied bachelor's degrees carry all of their students into the public 4-year sector. Sector series (enrollment shares, public 4-year tuition, graduation rates by sector) reflect these moves.

Research doctorates

Two counts appear. IPEDS counts degrees institutions report as "doctor's degree, research/scholarship", which includes some practice-oriented degrees such as many Ed.D.s; the NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates counts research doctorate recipients and is smaller. Each figure names which it uses. "STEM master's per STEM research doctorate" divides IPEDS STEM master's degrees by IPEDS STEM research doctorates.

Engineering

"Engineering" alone is CIP 14. Where engineering technology (CIP 15) is added, the label says "engineering & eng. technology".

Graduation rates

IPEDS graduation rates follow first-time, full-time students and count only those who finish at the institution where they started, so they leave out part-time starters and students who transfer and finish elsewhere.

International students in SEVIS

SEVIS counts active F-1 and M-1 records, which include graduates on Optional Practical Training (up to 36 months for STEM graduates, 12 for others), so STEM shares run high. STEM follows the DHS STEM Designated Degree Program List, which is broader than the eight CIP families above, and DHS draws its STEM pages on a different basis from its all-student pages, so a country's STEM count can exceed its all-level count.

Visas and green cards

DOL labor condition applications (H-1B positions) are counted by worksite and include renewals and job changes; USCIS approvals are counted by the employer's address and split into new and continuing. PERM certifications are the employer's step toward a green card.

Patents

Patents are counted by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live; a company headquartered in another state takes its patents there.

Years

Each measure uses its latest year, so years differ across a page; every figure, table and statement gives its year, and lines that stop early are labeled with their last year.

South Dakota – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	285	**281**[2024]	−3.5 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#6	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	34%	**33%**[2024]	−0.4 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#6	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	240	**240**[2024]	+0.2 ▲	237	−2.5 ▼	#11	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	40%	**42%**[2024]	+2.7 pp ▲	39%	0.0 pp	#12	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	267	**260**[2024]	−7.2 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#16	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	34%	**29%**[2024]	−5.6 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#25	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	220	**214**[2024]	−6.4 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#31	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**160**[2015]	–	153	–	#8	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$11.9K	**$13.1K**[2021]	+9.6% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#40	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	84%	**82%**[2022]	−2.0 pp ▼	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#40	[3]
Public high school graduates	8.17K	**8.94K**[2024]	+9.4% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#46	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$53.5K	**$54.6K**[2022]	+2.0% ▲	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#50	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	13.9	**13.8**[2022]	−0.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#29	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	134K	**141K**[2024]	+5.1% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#45	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	40%	**33%**[2023]	−6.9 pp ▼	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#44	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	3.8%	**4.6%**[2022]	+0.8 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#40	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	0.0%	**0.0%**[2020]	0.0 pp	6.8%	+1.4 pp ▲	#44	[3]
High schools offering calculus	41%[2016]	**33%**[2024]	−7.2 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#44	[14]
High schools offering physics	60%[2016]	**51%**[2024]	−8.9 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#39	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	84%[2016]	**81%**[2024]	−3.8 pp ▼	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#28	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	92%[2016]	**87%**[2024]	−5.1 pp ▼	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#36	[14]
High schools offering computer science	65%[2021]	**50%**[2024]	−14.8 pp ▼	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#36	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	35%[2016]	**24%**[2024]	−10.8 pp ▼	56%	0.0 pp	#49	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	1.7%[2021]	**3.2%**[2024]	+1.5 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#49	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	76%[2016]	**74%[2024]**	−1.4 pp ▼	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#30	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	9.0[2016]	**10.8[2024]**	+1.8 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#47	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	4.2[2016]	**2.3[2024]**	−1.9 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#37	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	6.9[2016]	**9.4[2024]**	+2.5 ▲	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#20	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	21.7[2016]	**15.9[2024]**	−5.8 ▼	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#37	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	2.0[2016]	**2.9[2024]**	+0.9 ▲	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#34	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	32%	**27%[2025]**	−5.2 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#46	[15]
Fall enrollment	53.7K	**54.2K[2024]**	+0.9% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#46	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	82%	**84%[2024]**	+1.3 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#17	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	4.1%	**2.8%[2024]**	−1.3 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#21	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	38%	**40%[2024]**	+2.7 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#23	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	13%	**17%[2024]**	+3.9 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#20	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	20%	**31%[2024]**	+11.0 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#10	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	110	**135[2025]**	+23% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#47	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	91	**112[2025]**	+23% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#46	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	0.2%	**0.2%[2025]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#47	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	17	**25[2025]**	–	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#45	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	7	**23[2025]**	–	5.07K	+33% ▲	#36	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	5.4	**6.6[2025]**	+1.2 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#17	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	19%	**26%[2025]**	+6.7 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#15	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	3.4%	**6.3%[2025]**	+3.0 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#20	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	6.8%	**8.1%[2025]**	+1.4 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#11	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.0%	**1.1%[2025]**	+0.2 pp ▲	1.2%	0.0 pp	#15	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	5.4%	**6.8%**[2025]	+1.5 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#21	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.0%	**1.2%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#30	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	21%	**17%**[2025]	−4.1 pp ▼	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#7	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	13%	**14%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#48	[4]
STEM share of master's	21%	**27%**[2025]	+6.0 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#10	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	6.0%	**13%**[2025]	+6.6 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#8	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	8.2%	**7.8%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#12	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	1.5%	**1.3%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#21	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	2.4%	**2.4%**[2025]	0.0 pp	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#27	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	1.6%	**1.5%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#11	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	10%	**14%**[2025]	+3.4 pp ▲	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#29	[4]
Share of master's in business	15%	**20%**[2025]	+5.0 pp ▲	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#30	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	41%	**32%**[2025]	−9.0 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#41	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	3.4%	**13%**[2025]	+10.0 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#1	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	8.8%	**9.7%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#38	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	2.7%	**0.0%**[2025]	−2.7 pp ▼	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#49	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	12%	**3.6%**[2025]	−8.6 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#50	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	8.8%	**4.0%**[2025]	−4.9 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#45	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	11%	**4.7%**[2025]	−6.2 pp ▼	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#41	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	0.0%	**31%**[2025]	+31.4 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#1	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	11.9	**12.3**[2025]	+0.4 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#31	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.8%[2016]	**5.4%**[2024]	+3.7 pp ▲	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#4	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	120	**277**[2025]	2.31× ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#39	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.2%	**0.2%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#39	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	2.3%	**3.4%**[2024]	+1.1 pp ▲	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#14	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	11%	**13%**[2024]	+2.0 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#26	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	1.5%	**3.3%**[2025]	+1.8 pp ▲	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#25	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	3.5%	**4.8%**[2025]	+1.3 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#27	[4]
International share of all master's	10%	**18%**[2025]	+7.8 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#23	[4]
International share of STEM master's	37%	**48%**[2025]	+10.4 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#22	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	52%	**70%**[2025]	+18.2 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#19	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	44%	**36%**[2025]	−8.1 pp ▼	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#34	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	37%[2021]	**27%**[2023]	−9.8 pp ▼	54%	−0.6 pp ▼	#28	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	19%	**14%**[2025]	−5.2 pp ▼	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#33	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	24%[2016]	**24%**[2025]	0.0 pp	33%	+3.5 pp ▲	#32	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	38%	**29%**[2025]	−9.2 pp ▼	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#19	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	58%	**40%**[2025]	−18.6 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#28	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	–	**2.7%**[2025]	–	56%	–	#26	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	63%[2021]	**63%**[2022]	0.0 pp	59%	−0.7 pp ▼	#15	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	1.91K	**2.77K**[2026]	+46% ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#43	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.2%	**0.2%**[2026]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#43	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	16%	**17%**[2026]	+1.1 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#31	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	12%	**4.1%**[2026]	−8.3 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#43	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	28%	**34%**[2026]	+5.6 pp ▲	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#33	[20]
Countries of citizenship represented	116	**121**[2026]	+4.3% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#44	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	1.12K	**1.74K**[2026]	+55% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#43	[20]
Active STEM master's students	433	**621**[2026]	+43% ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#42	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	289	**434**[2026]	+50% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#42	[20]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Share of STEM master's students from India	38%	**36%**[2026]	−1.8 pp ▼	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#41	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	864[2017]	**800**[2024]	−7.4% ▼	–	–	#42	[1]
Economic contribution of international students, nominal dollars	$45.4M[2018]	**$67.1M**[2024]	+48% ▲	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#46	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	320[2018]	**350**[2024]	+9.4% ▲	356K	−22% ▼	#47	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#50	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#48	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.3%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#49	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	1.55K	**1.26K**[2025]	−19% ▼	275K	−14% ▼	#44	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	1.7K	**1.64K**[2016]	−3.7% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#46	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	606	**648**[2016]	+6.9% ▲	241K	+2.3% ▲	#42	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	36%	**40%**[2016]	+3.9 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#14	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	47%	**62%**[2016]	+14.9 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#9	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	47	**68**[2016]	–	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#46	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	74%	**72%**[2016]	−2.4 pp ▼	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#1	[9]
University R&D spending, nominal dollars	$103M	**$142M**[2024]	+38% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#51	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	0.2%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#51	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	49%	**51%**[2024]	+2.6 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#30	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	3.0%	**2.7%**[2024]	−0.3 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#36	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	19%	**15%**[2024]	−3.5 pp ▼	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#4	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science, nominal dollars	$2.36M	**$7.8M**[2024]	3.31× ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#46	[6]
University R&D in engineering, nominal dollars	$18.8M	**$26.3M**[2024]	+40% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#50	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	2.04K	**2.08K**[2024]	+2.0% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#50	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$72.8M	**$130M**[2024]	+78% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#50	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state, nominal dollars	$35.8M	**$47.8M**[2024]	+33% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#51	[8]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
Defense R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$5.82M	**$19.6M[2024]**	3.36× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#50	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state, nominal dollars	$21.4M	**$29.6M[2024]**	+38% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#48	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state, nominal dollars	$45.2M	**$104M[2025]**	2.31× ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#43	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state, nominal dollars	$3.99M	**$31.6M[2026]**	+27.6 ▲	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#39	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$50.1K[2020]	**$51K[2022]**	+1.9% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#18	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$50K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#19	[15]
Median debt of completers, nominal dollars	$25K	**$21K[2024]**	−16% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#6	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$68.5K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#21	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$49.7K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#30	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$63.2K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#40	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$100K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#9	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	50%	**58%[2024]**	+7.8 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#40	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	60%	**67%[2024]**	+7.0 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#3	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$10.9K	**$9.25K[2023]**	−15% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#33	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$7.54K	**$9.61K[2024]**	+28% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#35	[4]
Net tuition share of tuition plus state and local appropriations, public institutions	56%	**45%[2024]**	−11.5 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#28	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$85.8K[2016]	**$79.3K[2024]**	−7.6% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#47	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	18%	**23%[2016]**	+4.8 pp ▲	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#45	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	21%	**38%[2016]**	+16.4 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#39	[21]
OPT retention, master's graduates	11%	**13%[2016]**	+2.2 pp ▲	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#48	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	16%	**20%[2016]**	+4.0 pp ▲	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#43	[21]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.31	**0.33**[2016]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#50	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	73	**95**[2016]	+30% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#41	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	56%[2016]	**55%**[2019]	−0.8 pp ▼	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#28	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**50%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#28	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**52%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#23	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	43%[2016]	**45%**[2019]	+1.5 pp ▲	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#29	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**46%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#33	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**37%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#31	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$47.8K[2016]	**$49.8K**[2019]	+4.0% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#9	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$63K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#23	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$57K[2016]	**$57.6K**[2019]	+1.0% ▲	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#19	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	−10.2	**−14.1**[2025]	−3.9 ▼	–	–	#50	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	−137	**−831**[2025]	−694.0 ▼	–	–	#37	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	2.3%	**2.4%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#33	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.3%	**3.8%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	–	–	#6	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	996	**1.92K**[2025]	+93% ▲	–	–	#44	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	62%[2016]	**58%**[2024]	−4.0 pp ▼	–	–	#45	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+21[2016]	**+22**[2024]	+0.5 ▲	–	–	#12	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	24%[2016]	**26%**[2022]	+1.6 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#22	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	717	**620**[2025]	−14% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#45	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.1%	**0.1%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#45	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	75%	**26%**[2025]	−48.5 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#47	[17]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$64.7K	**$69.1K**[2025]	+6.8% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#51	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	48%	**6.0%**[2025]	−42.3 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#44	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	52	**441**[2025]	8.48× ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#37	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	15%	**3.8%**[2024]	−11.6 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#48	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	4.1%	**20%**[2024]	+16.2 pp ▲	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#3	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	38%	**6.6%**[2024]	−31.9 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#50	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	16%	**8.2%**[2025]	−7.5 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#49	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars, nominal dollars	$90.4K	**$34.3K**[2025]	−62% ▼	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#48	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	1.26K	**1.07K**[2024]	−15% ▼	1.36M	+30% ▲	#47	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#47	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	542	**680**[2024]	+25% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#47	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#47	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#48	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#49	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#51	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.0%	**0.0%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#49	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	73	**201**[2026]	2.75× ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#43	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	65	**762**[2026]	11.72× ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#35	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.1%	**0.2%**[2026]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#43	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	3.9%	**3.4%**[2026]	−0.6 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#30	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	41%	**23%**[2026]	−18.2 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#21	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	6.8%	**5.5%**[2026]	−1.4 pp ▼	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#49	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	64%	**59%**[2026]	−5.7 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#7	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

SOUTH DAKOTA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION (CONTINUED)							
Workers in STEM occupations	15.2K	**28.1K**[2024]	+85% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#48	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	3.5%	**5.8%**[2024]	+2.3 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#43	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	3.4%	**7.6%**[2024]	+4.2 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#44	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	2.5%	**2.8%**[2024]	+0.3 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#48	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	2.3%	**2.8%**[2024]	+0.5 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#46	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	3.2%	**3.8%**[2025]	+0.6 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#47	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	5.2%	**9.2%**[2025]	+4.0 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#41	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	16.6K	**21.8K**[2025]	+31% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#47	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.68	**0.72**[2025]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#44	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$61.7K	**$88.8K**[2025]	+44% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#50	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal, nominal dollars	$74.8K[2019]	**$96.3K**[2025]	+29% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#49	[10]
Software developer jobs	1.28K	**2.38K**[2025]	+86% ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#44	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal, nominal dollars	$38.8K	**$57.6K**[2025]	+48% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#45	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	61	**71**[2025]	+16% ▲	135K	−0.6% ▼	#47	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.0%	**0.1%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#47	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	13%	**9.9%**[2025]	−2.8 pp ▼	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#41	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	25%	**24%**[2025]	−1.5 pp ▼	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#14	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	0.0%	**0.0%**[2025]	0.0 pp	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#44	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	6.4%	**9.1%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#44	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

Sources

[1] Institute of International Education. *Open Doors Report on International Educational Exchange: State Fact Sheets*. Editions 2020–2026. New York: Institute of International Education. https://opendoorsdata.org/. Accessed November 2026.

[2] NAFSA: Association of International Educators. *NAFSA International Student Economic Value Tool*. Academic years 2018–19 to 2024–25. Washington, DC: NAFSA. https://www.nafsa.org/isev. Accessed November 2026.

[3] National Center for Education Statistics. *Digest of Education Statistics*. Editions 1995–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/. Accessed November 2026.

[4] National Center for Education Statistics. *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)*. Survey files, 1980–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/. Accessed November 2026.

[5] National Center for Education Statistics. *National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)*. NAEP Data Service, 1990–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[6] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Higher Education Research and Development Survey*. Data tables, FY2003–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/higher-education-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[7] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Earned Doctorates*. Data tables, 1994–2025. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates. Accessed November 2026.

[8] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Federal Funds for Research and Development*. Data tables, FY1985–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/federal-funds-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[9] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates in Science and Engineering*. Data tables, 1994–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/graduate-students-postdoctorates-s-e. Accessed November 2026.

[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics*. State estimates, 1999–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.bls.gov/oes/. Accessed November 2026.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies. *Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO)*. Release R2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/pseo_experimental.html. Accessed November 2026.

[12] U.S. Census Bureau. *American Community Survey*. 1-year estimates and Public Use Microdata Sample, 2010–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://data.census.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[13] U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. *H-1B Employer Data Hub*. Fiscal years 2009–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.uscis.gov/tools/reports-and-studies/h-1b-employer-data-hub. Accessed November 2026.

[14] U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. School years 1980–81 to 2023–24. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://civilrightsdata.ed.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[15] U.S. Department of Education. *College Scorecard*. Institution and field-of-study data, 1996–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://collegescorecard.ed.gov/data/. Accessed November 2026.

[16] U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics. *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics*. Fiscal years 1996–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook. Accessed November 2026.

[17] U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Office of Foreign Labor Certification. *LCA and PERM Disclosure Data*. Fiscal years 2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/performance. Accessed November 2026.

[18] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. *BridgeUSA: Exchange Visitor Program Participants by State*. 2015–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State. https://j1visa.state.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[19] U.S. Department of the Treasury, Bureau of the Fiscal Service. *USAspending.gov*. Award data, FY2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Treasury. https://www.usaspending.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[20] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Student and Exchange Visitor Program. *SEVIS by the Numbers: Data Mapping Tool*. Monthly data, 2014–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/sevis-data-mapping-tool. Accessed November 2026.

[21] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. *Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) Data*. Freedom of Information Act releases, 2008–2016. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.ice.gov/foia/library. Accessed November 2026.

[22] U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. *PatentsView*. Annualized patent data, grant years 1976–2025. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. https://patentsview.org/. Accessed November 2026.